THE PIANO BUTLER · LEVEL BOOK

Prelim

One step on each page: a big picture, a few words, and one thing to try at the piano. After each room, a page to practise. The last room trains your ears.

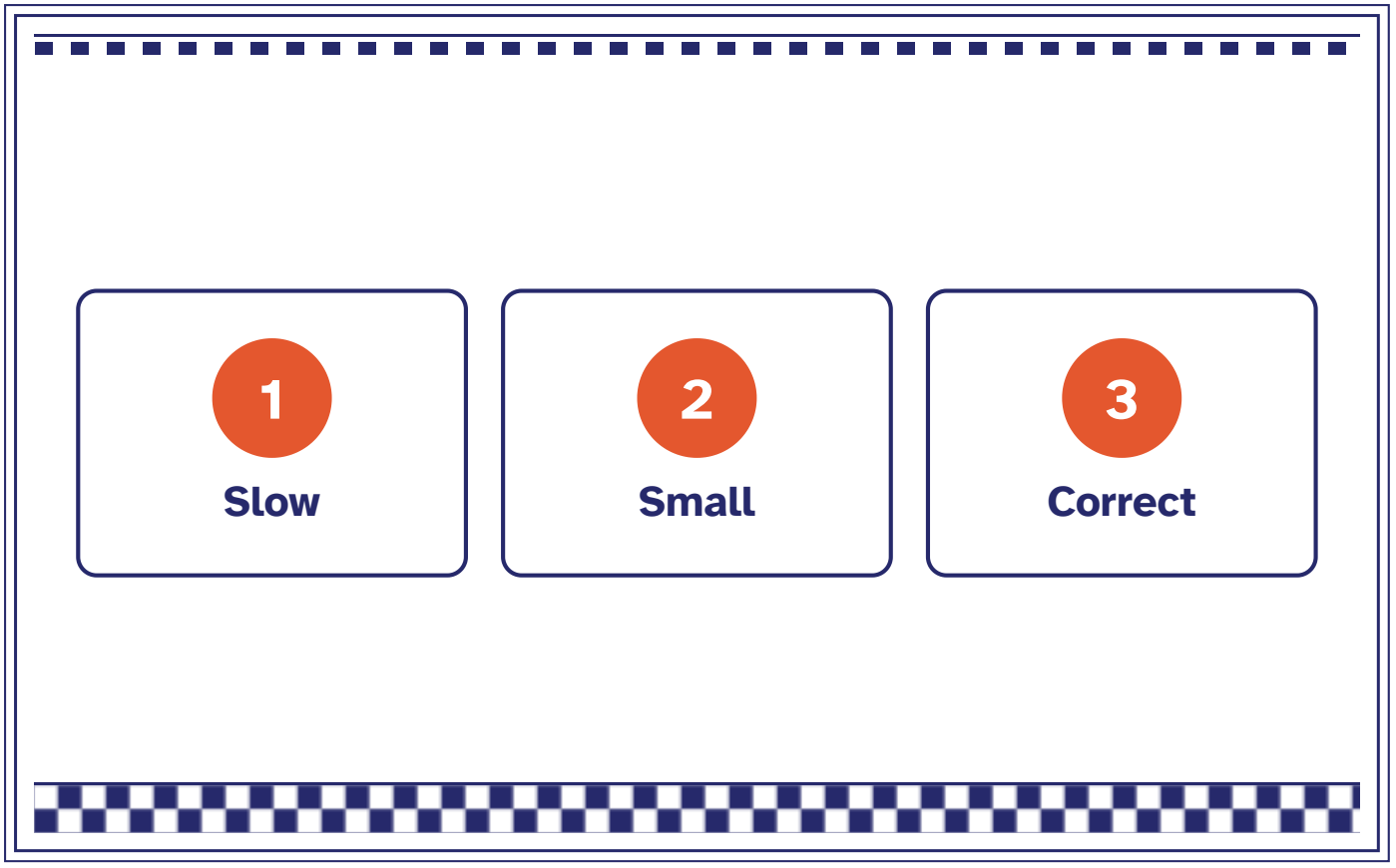
THE ROOMS

1 · Practising well
2 · Loud and soft
3 · The staff and the keyboard
4 · Reading the notes
5 · How long is a note?
6 · Time signatures
7 · Repeats
8 · Touch: smooth and short
9 · Major scales
10 · Minor scales
11 · Chords and triads
12 · Ear training

PRACTISING WELL

ROOM 1 · STEP 1 OF 3

SCAN TO LISTEN



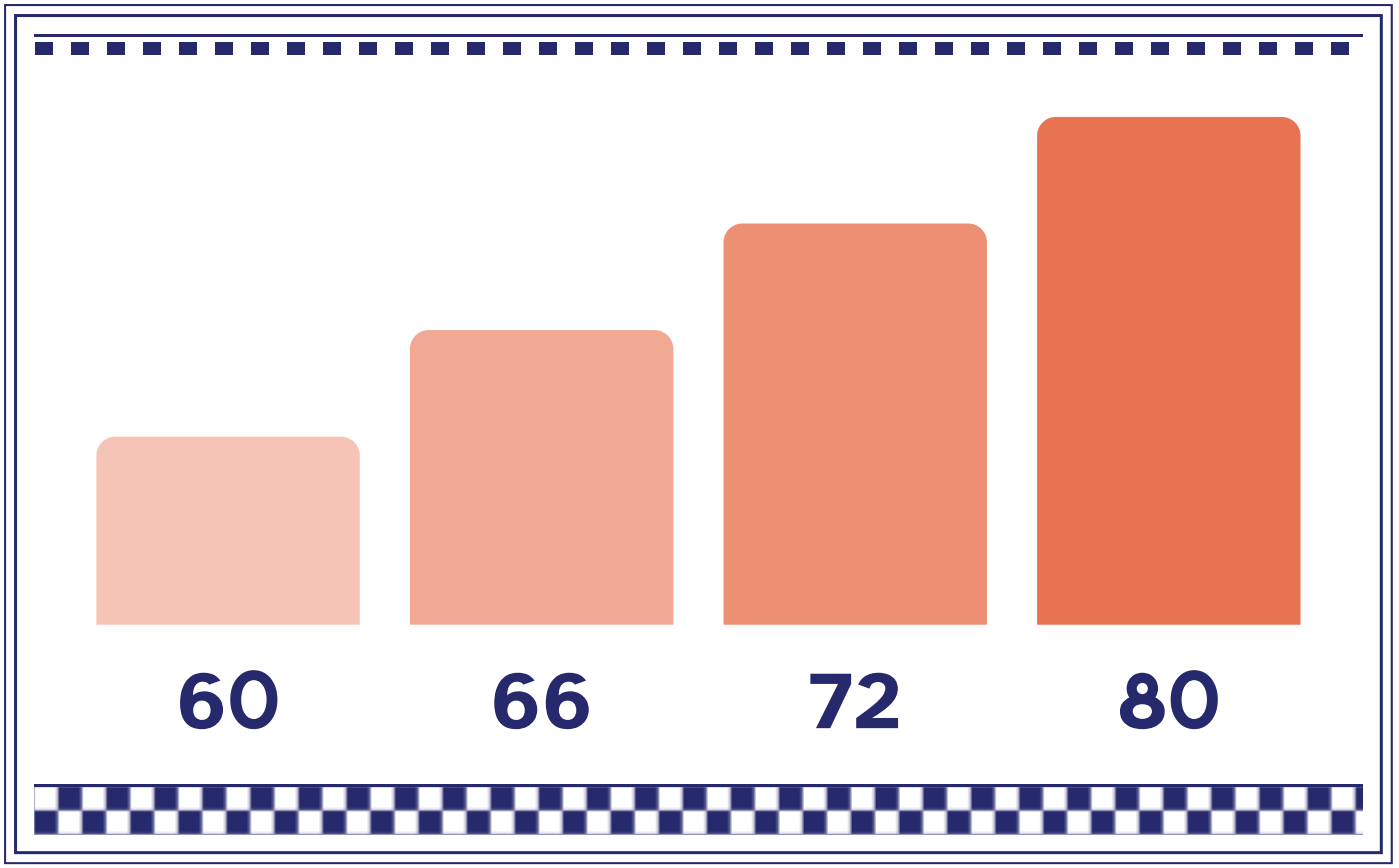
Good practice is **slow**, **small** and **correct**.

Slow enough to get it right. A small piece at a time. And right from the very first try.

At the piano

- [ ] Choose two bars of your piece. Play them at half speed, with no wrong notes. ○

ROOM 1 · STEP 2 OF 3



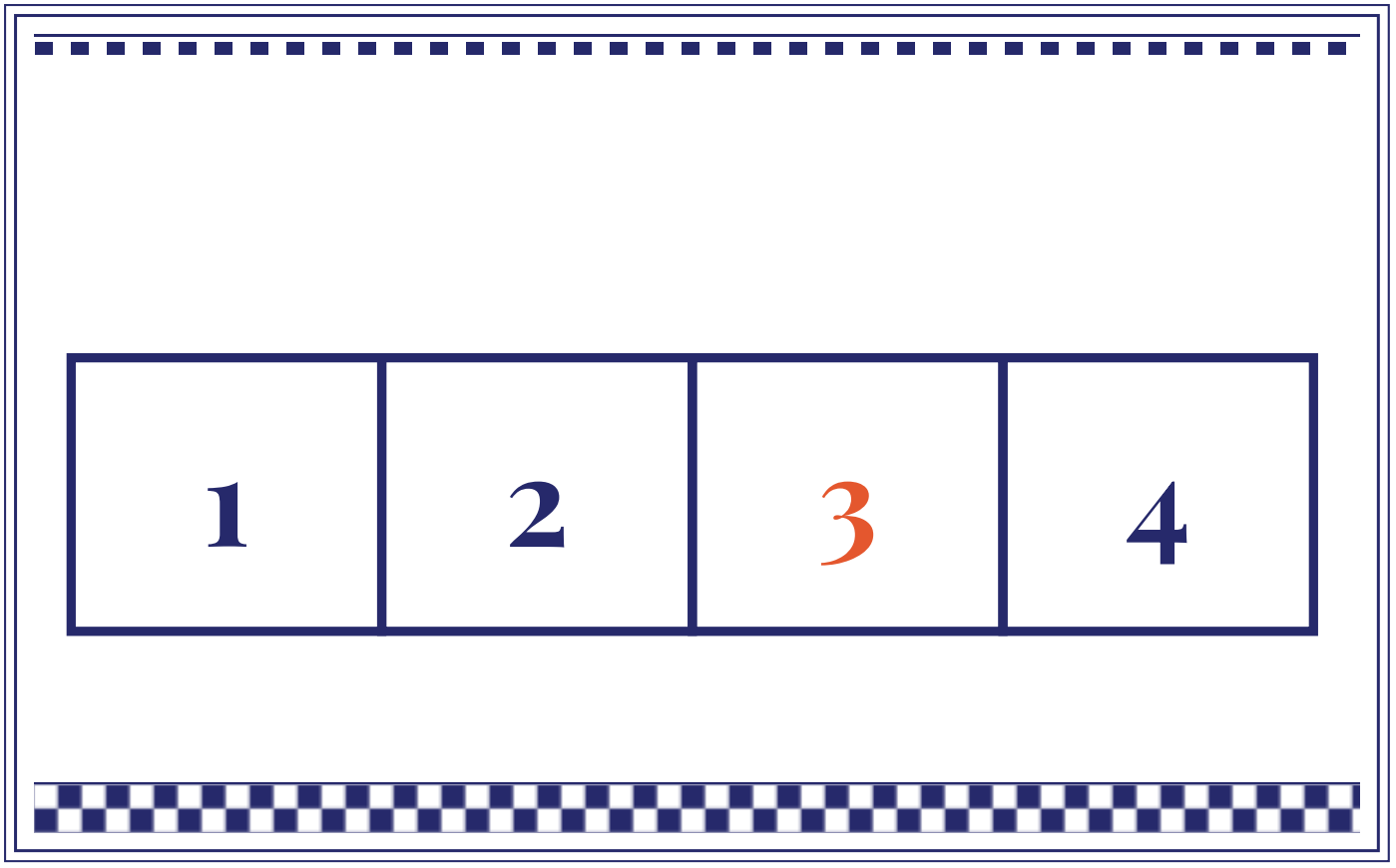
When it is right **three times** in a row, go **one step faster**.

If it falls apart, step back down. This is the metronome ladder.

At the piano

- [ ] Set a metronome (a ticking beat-keeper; there is one in the app) to 60. Play your two bars three times. All right? Move up to 66.

ROOM 1 · STEP 3 OF 3



Every piece has a **hardest bar**. Find it and practise it **first**, while your mind is fresh.

Then join it to the bar before and the bar after.

At the piano

- [ ] Find the hardest bar in your piece. Play it slowly five times, then play it with its neighbours. ◯

ROOM 1 · PRACTISE

1 Good habit?

★☆☆

Circle helps or wastes time. The first is done.

the hardest bar first	**helps** · wastes time
always from the top	helps · wastes time
play faster after a slip	helps · wastes time
three correct, then faster	helps · wastes time
hands separately first	helps · wastes time

2 My fifteen minutes

★★☆

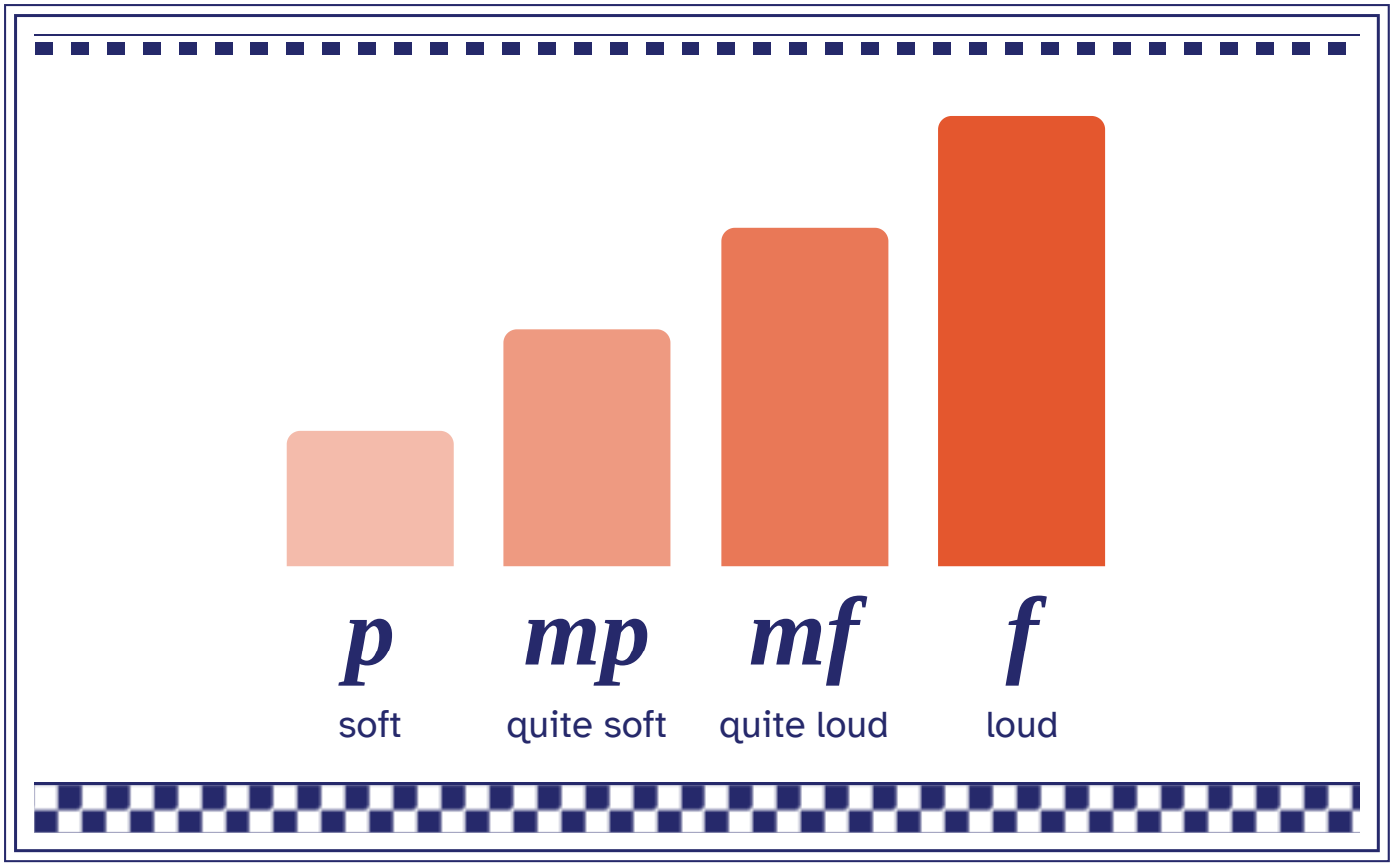
Plan your practice: what will you do in each part?

TIME	WHAT
2 min · warm up	
5 min · hardest bars	
5 min · join them	
3 min · play it through	

LOUD AND SOFT

ROOM 2 · STEP 1 OF 3

SCAN TO LISTEN



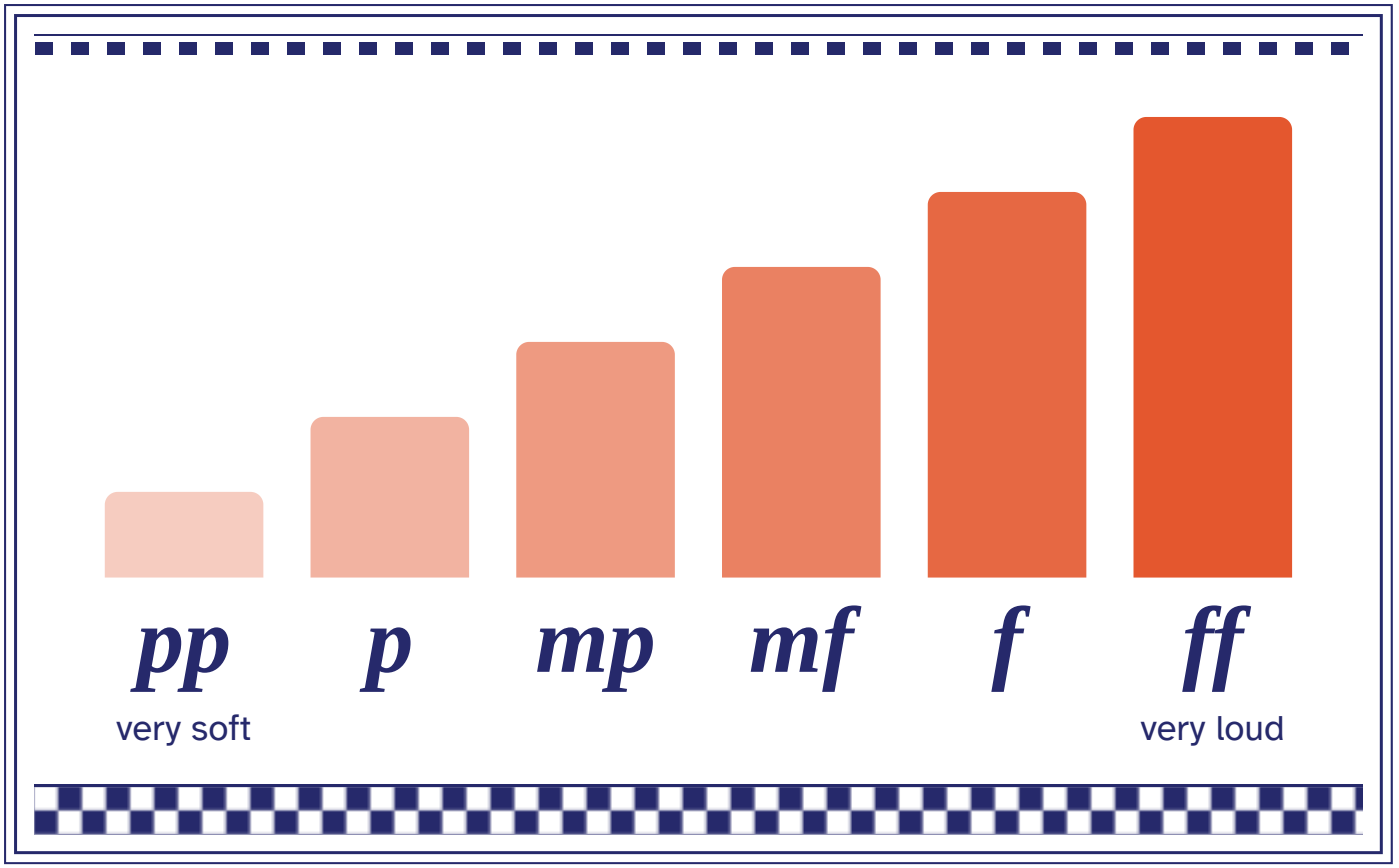
Four signs tell you how loud to play. ***p*** is *piano*, soft. ***f*** is *forte*, loud.

Mezzo means medium: ***mp***, mezzo piano, is quite soft and ***mf***, mezzo forte, is quite loud.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C four times: p, mp, mf, f. Four steps, the same speed.

ROOM 2 · STEP 2 OF 3



Two letters mean **very**: ***pp*** is very soft, ***ff*** is very loud.

That makes six steps, from a whisper to a shout.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C six times, one step louder each time. Then come back down the steps.

ROOM 2 · STEP 3 OF 3



crescendo

getting louder



diminuendo

getting softer

A sign that **opens** means get louder little by little: **crescendo**. A sign that **closes** means get softer: **diminuendo**.

The wide end is the loud end.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C D E F G getting louder, then G F E D C getting softer.

ROOM 2 · PRACTISE

1 What does it mean?

★☆☆

Write the meaning. The first is done.

SIGN	MEANS
mp	quite soft
mf	
pp	
ff	

2 Softest to loudest

★★☆

Write the six signs in order, from the softest to the loudest. The first is done.

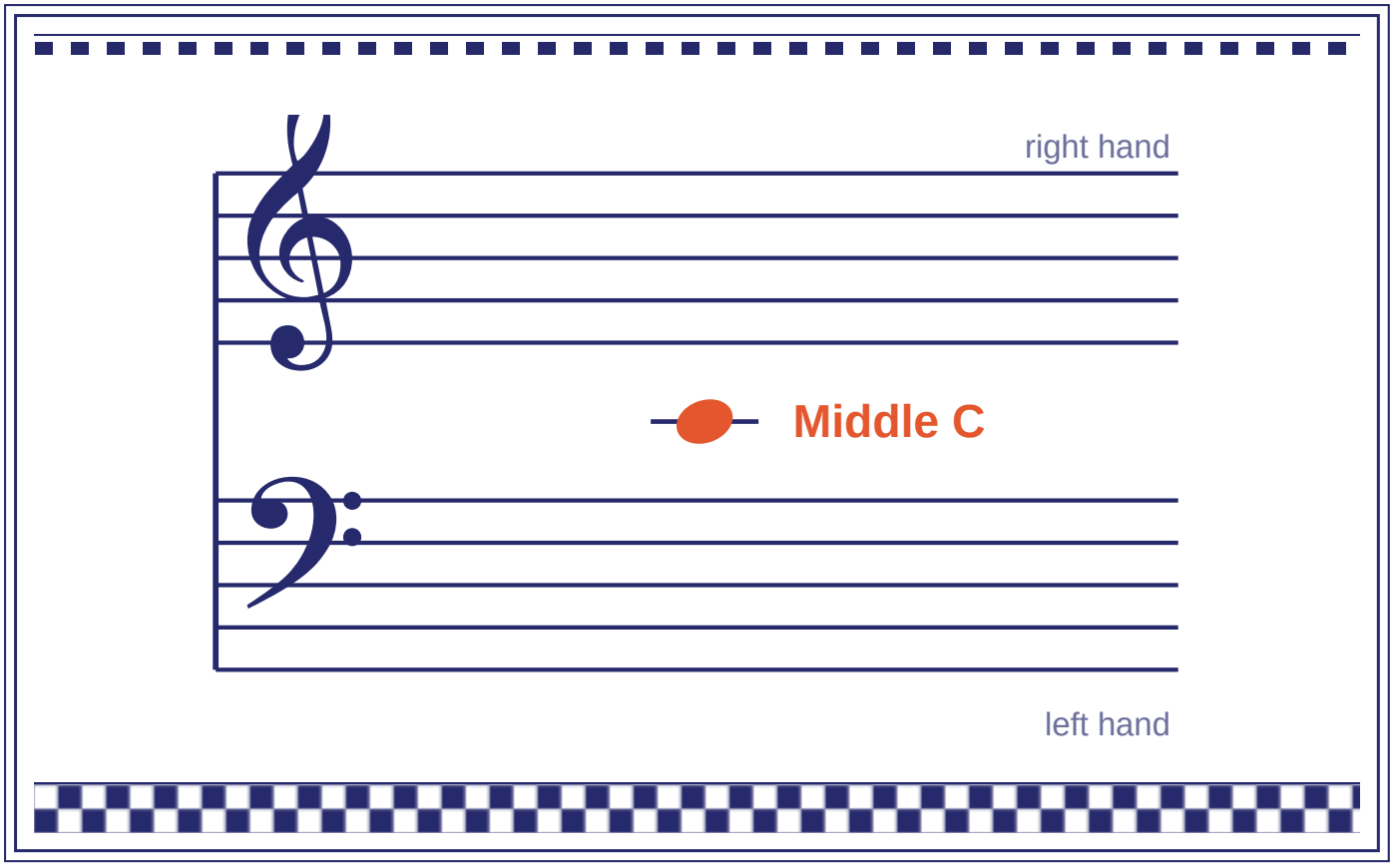
pp ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

f · mp · ff · p · mf

THE STAFF AND THE KEYBOARD

ROOM 3 · STEP 1 OF 2

SCAN TO LISTEN



Piano music uses **two staves** joined together: the top one for the right hand, the bottom one for the left.

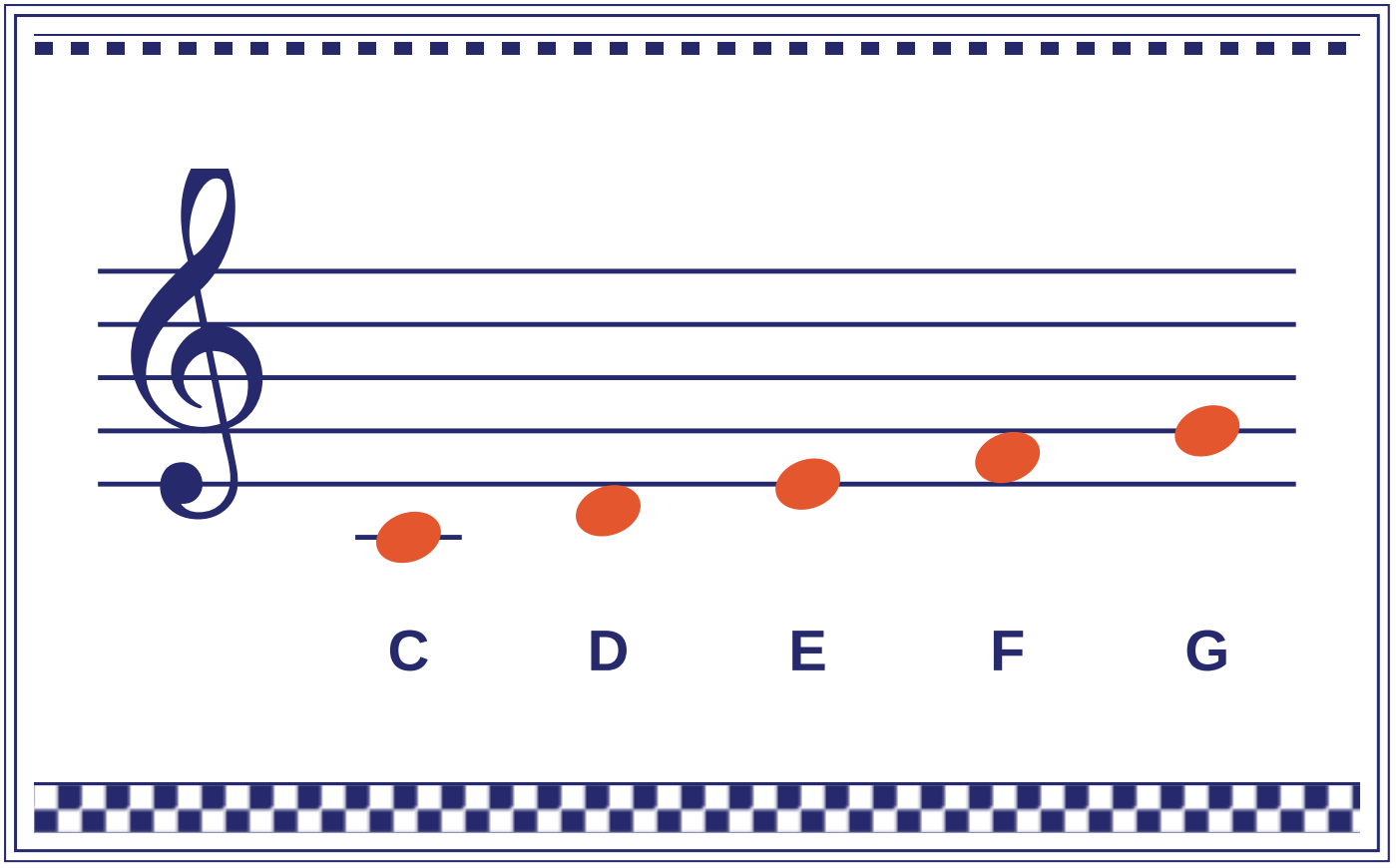
The curly sign at the top is the **treble clef**. The one below is the **bass clef**.

Middle C sits between them, on a little line of its own.

At the piano

- [ ] Find Middle C: the C nearest the middle of your piano. Play it with each thumb. ◯

ROOM 3 · STEP 2 OF 2



From Middle C, each **step up** on the staff, line to space, space to line, is the **next white key** to the right.

Line, space, line, space, line: C, D, E, F, G.

At the piano

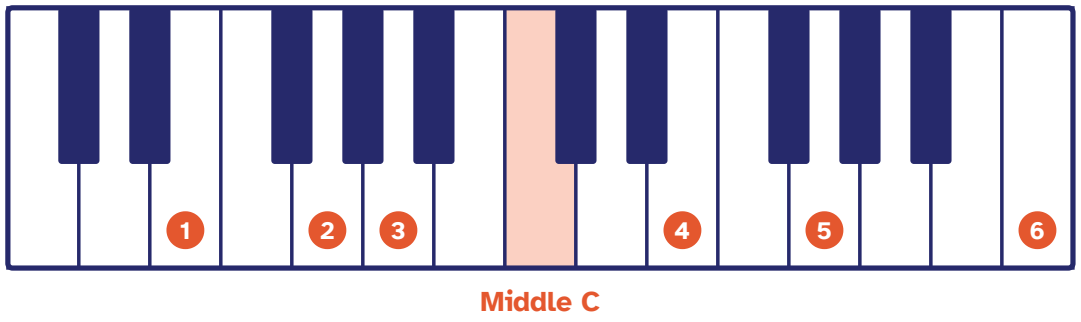
- [ ] Right thumb on Middle C. Play C D E F G while you look at the five notes on the staff.

ROOM 3 · PRACTISE

1 Which key?

★☆☆

Middle C is marked. Write the letter name of each numbered key. The first is done.



1 E 2 ____ 3 ____ 4 ____ 5 ____ 6 ____

2 Count from Middle C

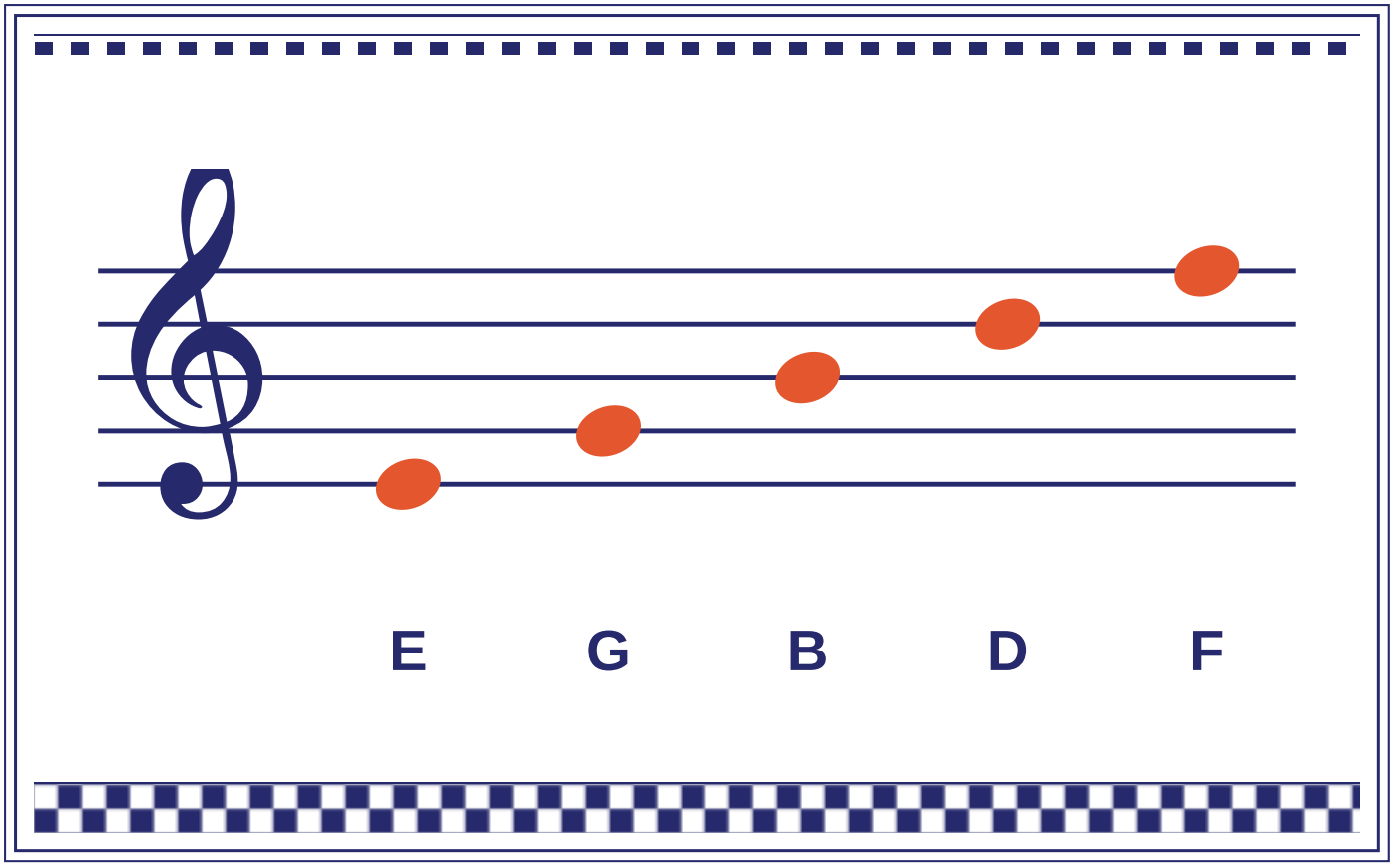
★☆☆

Count the notes, both ends included. The first is done.

FROM	TO	NOTES
Middle C	up to treble G	5
Middle C	down to bass F	
Middle C	up to A	
Middle C	down to E	
G	up to the next G	

ROOM 4 · STEP 1 OF 3

SCAN TO LISTEN



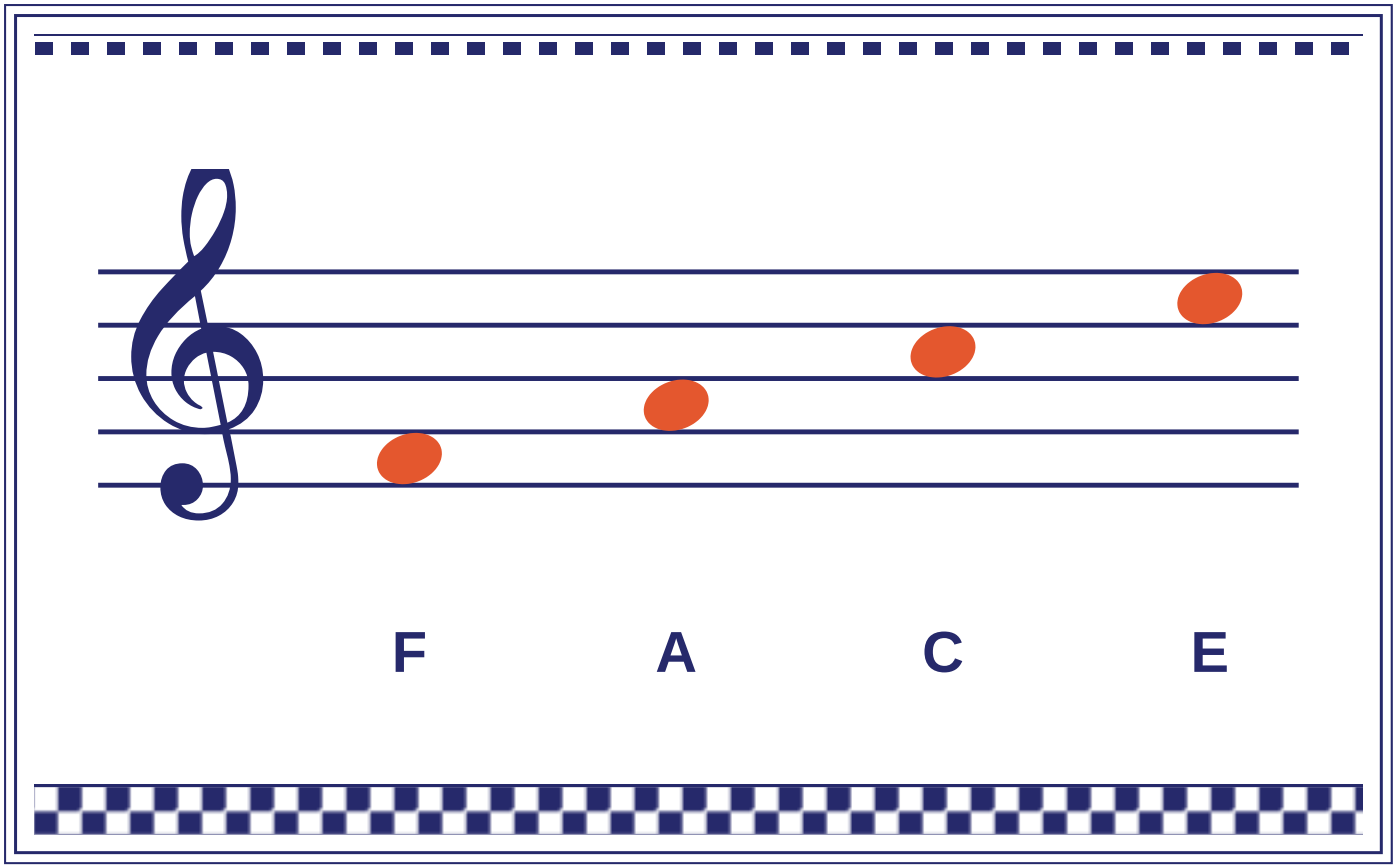
The five **lines** of the treble staff are **E G B D F**, from the bottom up.

A sentence helps: **E**very **G**ood **B**oy **D**eserves **F**un.

At the piano

- [ ] Play E G B D F going up from the E above Middle C, saying the sentence. ○

ROOM 4 · STEP 2 OF 3



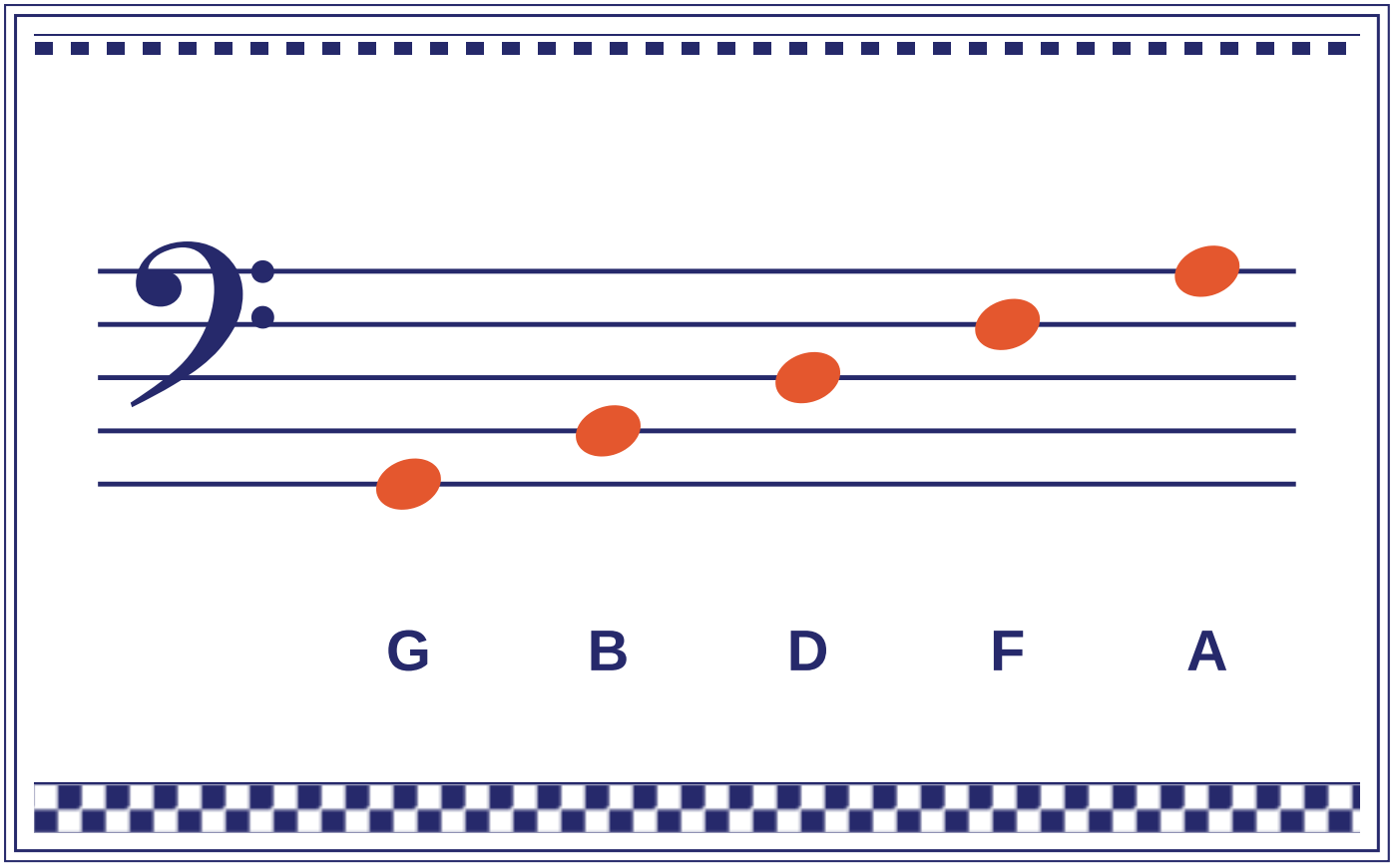
The four **spaces** of the treble staff spell a word: **F A C E**.

Lines and spaces take turns, so the notes go F, G, A, B, C, D, E.

At the piano

- [ ] Play F A C E going up. Then play F G A and say which is a space and which is a line. ○

ROOM 4 · STEP 3 OF 3



The bass staff is different. Its **lines** are **G B D F A**: **G**reat **B**ig **D**ragons **F**ly **A**way.

Its spaces are **A C E G**: **A**ll **C**ows **E**at **G**rass.

At the piano

- [ ] With your left hand, play G B D F A going up from the second G below Middle C, saying the sentence.

ROOM 4 · PRACTISE

1 The letters on the staff

★☆☆

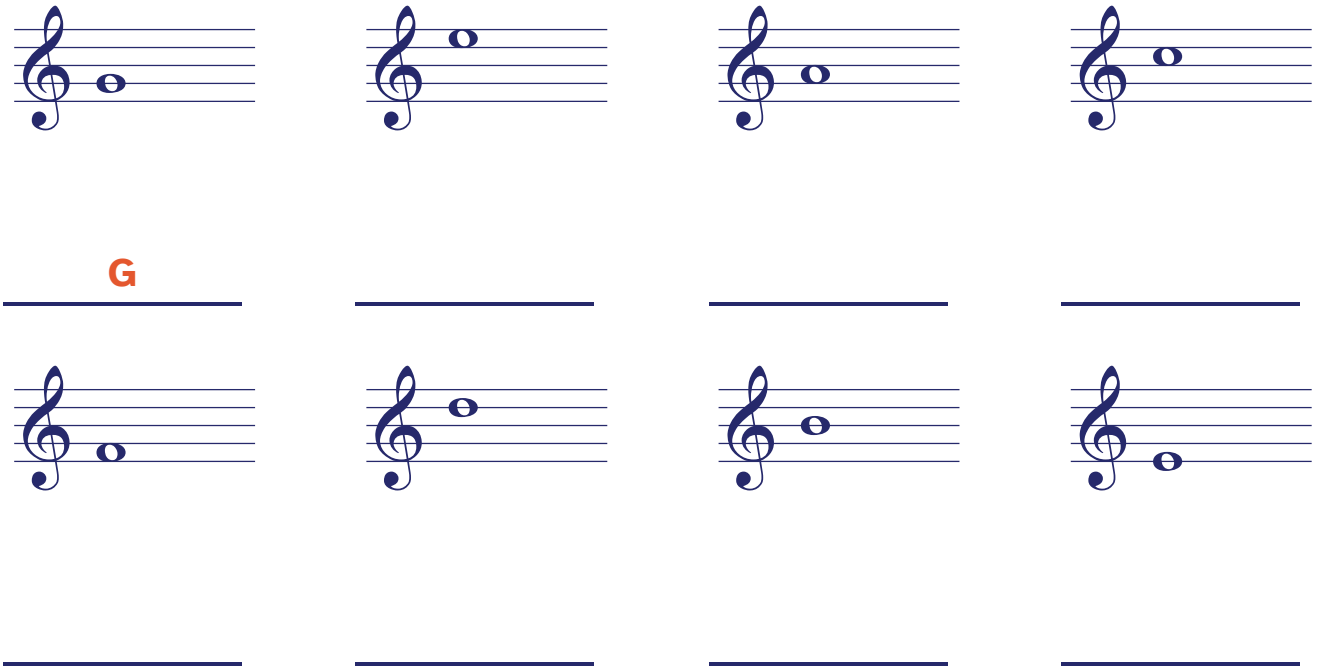
Write the letters from the bottom up. The first row is done.

Treble lines	E	G	B	D	F
Treble spaces					
Bass lines					
Bass spaces					

2 Treble clef notes

★☆☆

Write the letter name under each note. The first is done.

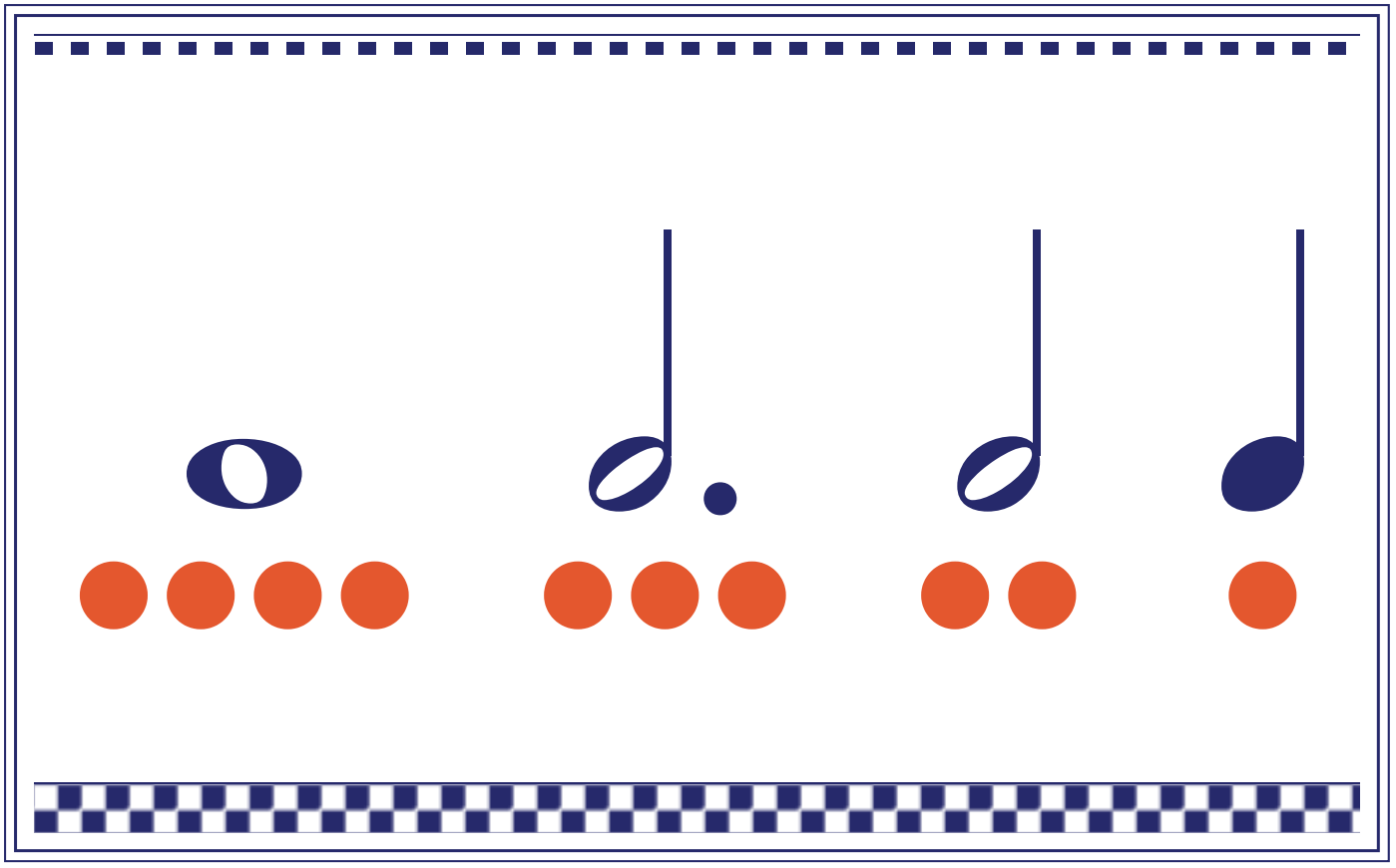


G

HOW LONG IS A NOTE?

ROOM 5 · STEP 1 OF 7

SCAN TO LISTEN



One circle is **one beat**. A **crotchet** is one circle. A **minim** is two, a **dotted minim** three and a **semibreve** four.

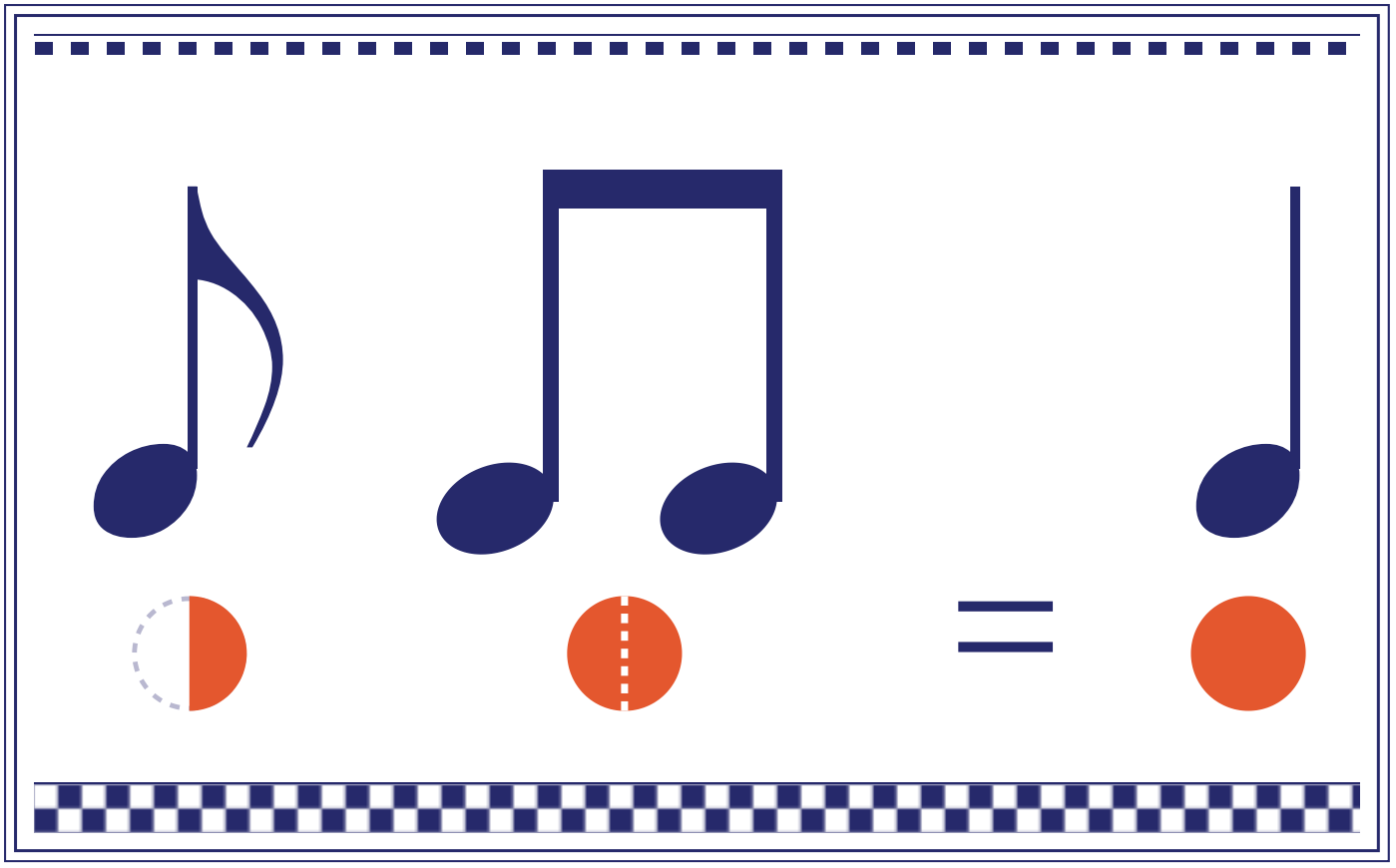
Now come the notes shorter than one beat: pieces of the circle.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C as a semibreve, a dotted minim, a minim and a crotchet, counting the beats out loud: 1 2 3 4.

HOW LONG IS A NOTE?

ROOM 5 · STEP 2 OF 7



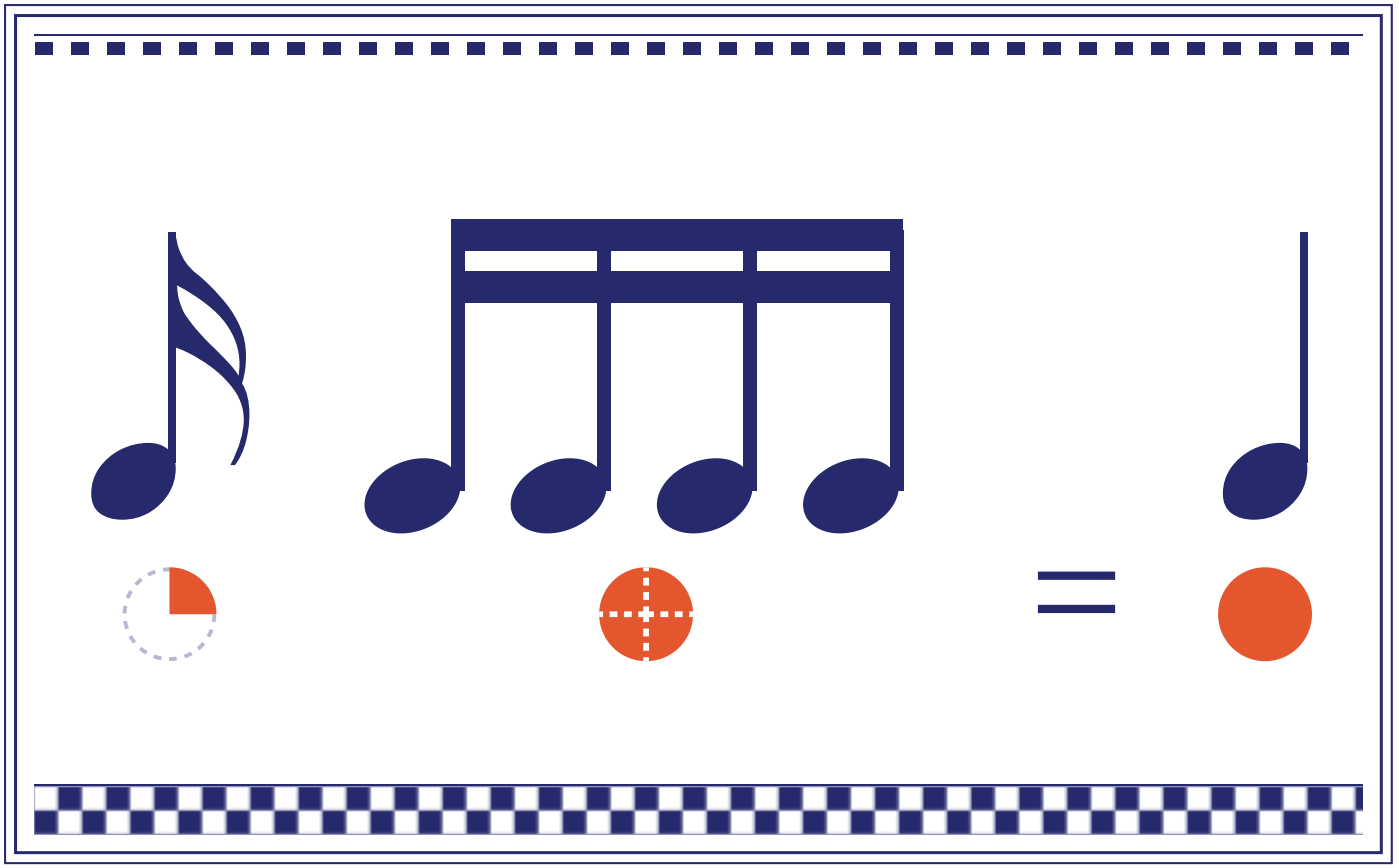
Cut the circle in half. A **quaver** is **half a beat**, and on its own it has a **tail**.

Put two halves together and you have one whole beat: two quavers joined by a **beam**. We count them **1 and**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C in crotchets, counting 1 2 3 4. Then in quavers, counting 1 and 2 and 3 and 4 and. ◯

ROOM 5 · STEP 3 OF 7



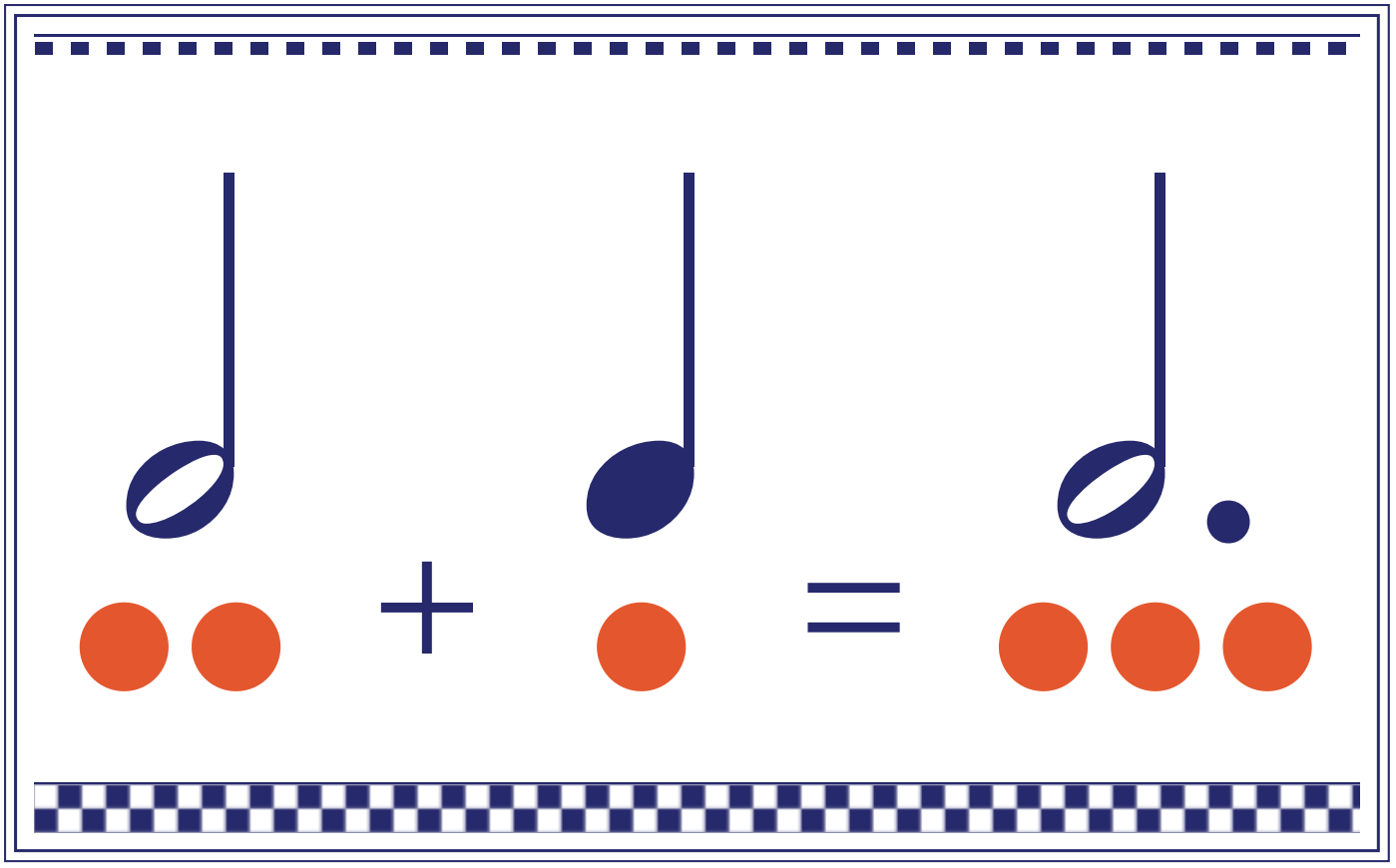
Cut each half again. A **semiquaver** is a **quarter of a beat**, and on its own it has **two tails**.

Put four quarters together and you have one whole beat: four semiquavers joined by **two beams**. Say **wa-ter-me-lon**.

At the piano

- [ ] Clap four beats. Then tap four semiquavers on every beat, saying wa-ter-me-lon. ◯

ROOM 5 · STEP 4 OF 7



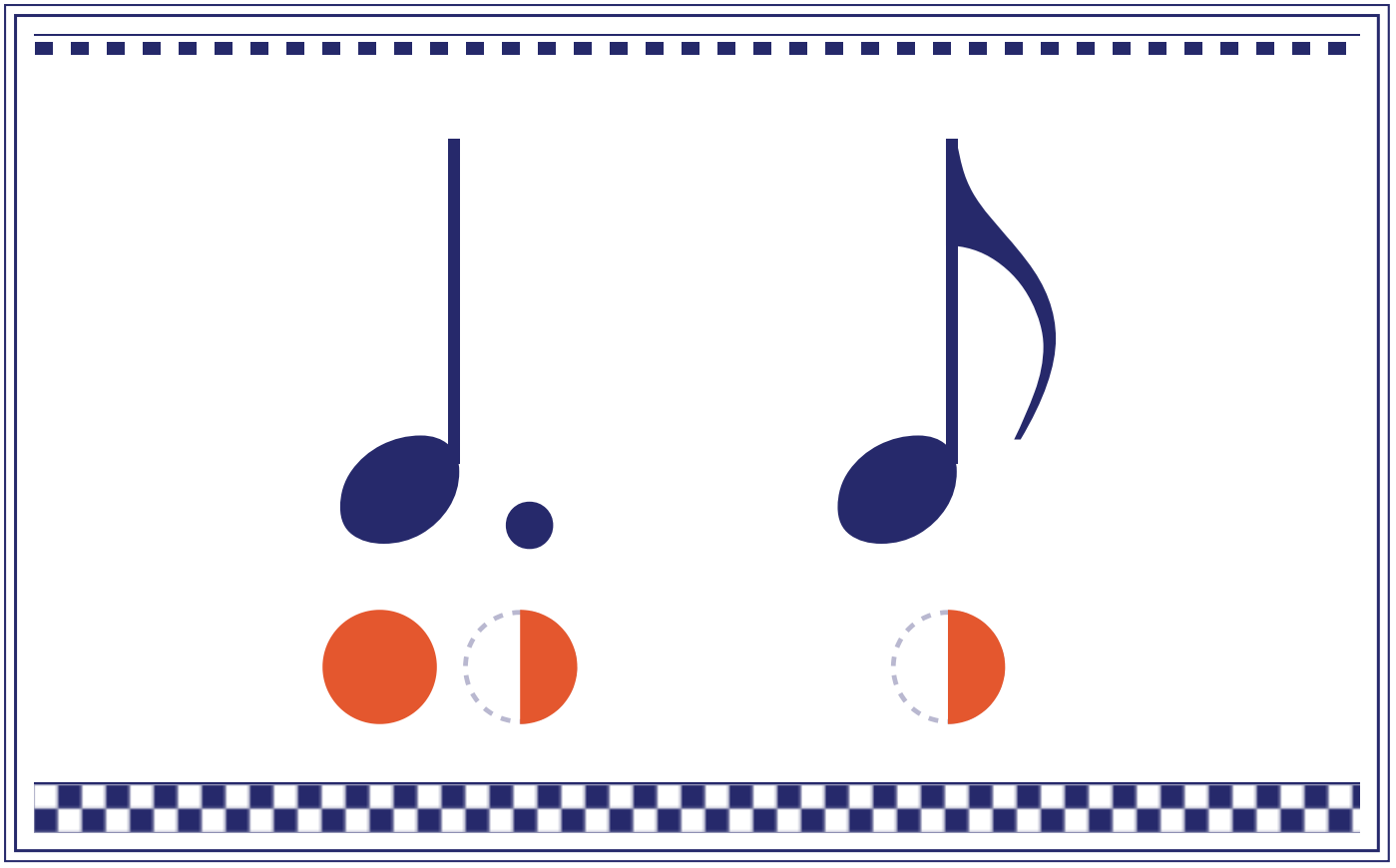
A **dot after a note** makes it longer: it adds **half** of the note again.

A minim is 2 beats. Half of 2 is 1. So a dotted minim is 2 + 1 = **3 beats**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C as a minim, counting 1 2. Then as a dotted minim, counting 1 2 3.

ROOM 5 · STEP 5 OF 7



The same dot works on a crotchet: 1 + ½. A **dotted crotchet** is **one beat and a half**.

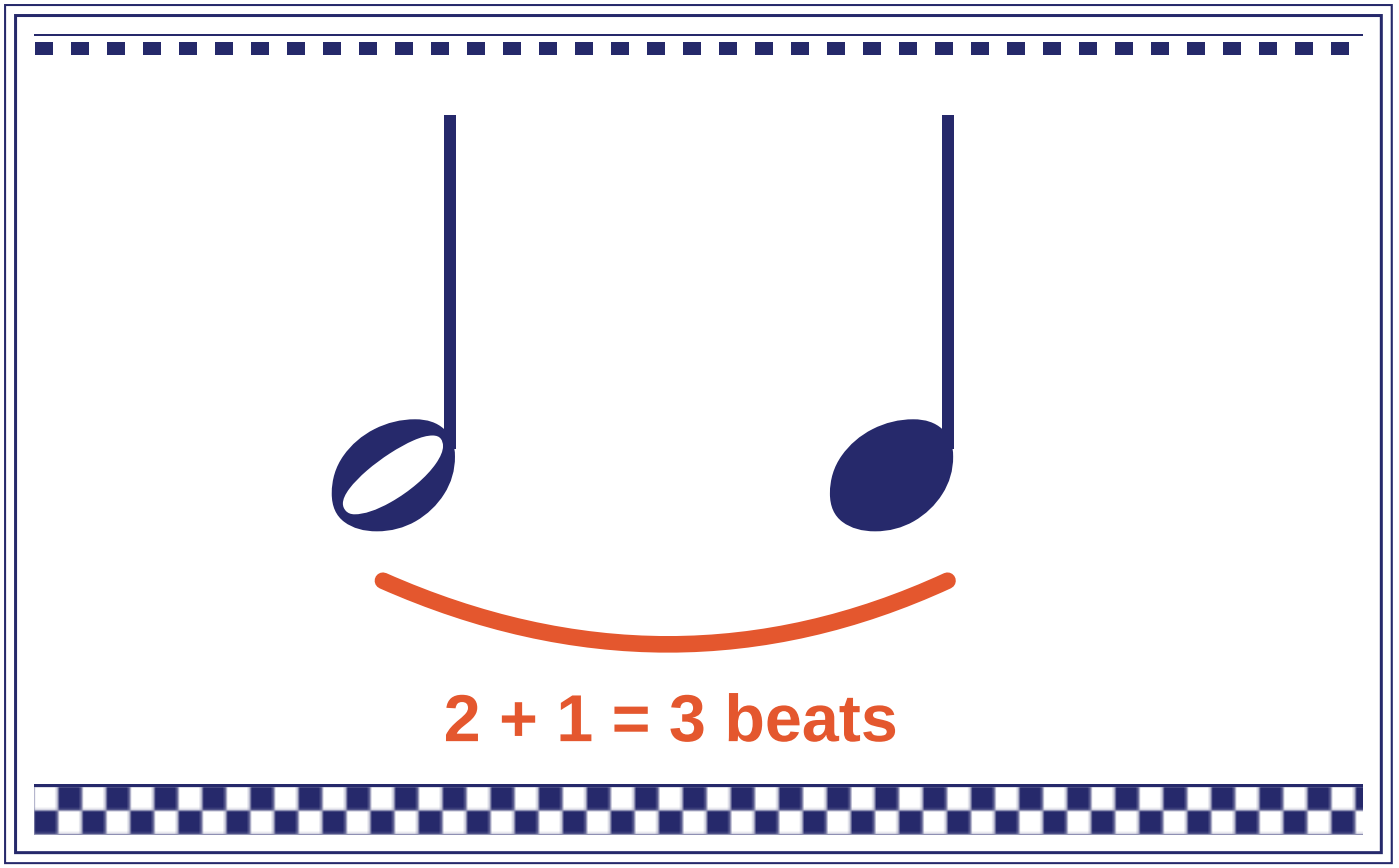
A quaver usually follows it to finish the second beat. Long, then short: **1 – 2 and**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C long, then D short, counting 1, 2 AND. The D comes on the "and". ◯

HOW LONG IS A NOTE?

ROOM 5 · STEP 6 OF 7



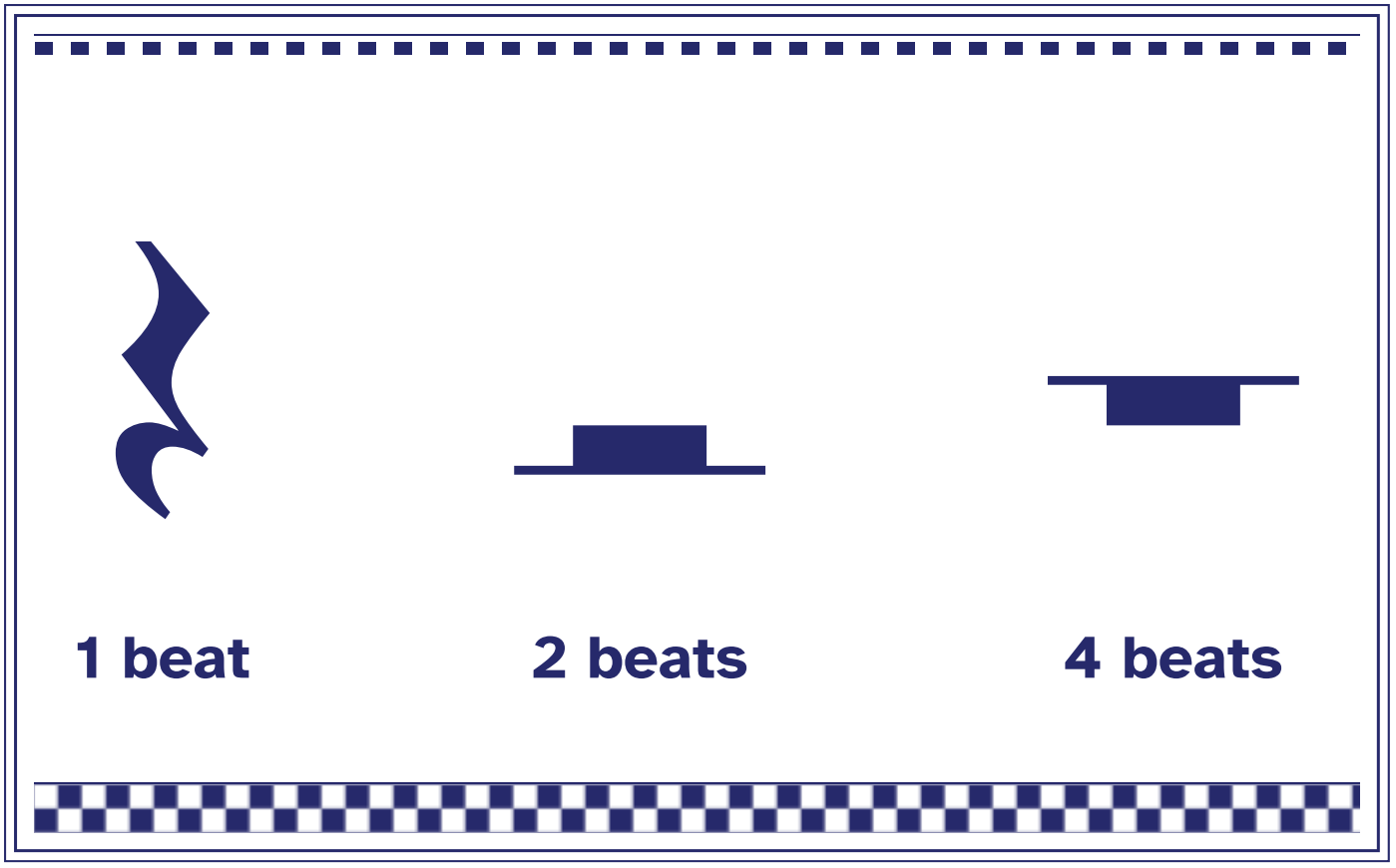
A **tie** is a curved line joining two notes of the **same** pitch. Play the first one and **hold** through the second.

A minim tied to a crotchet lasts three beats.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C and hold it for 1 2 3. You have played two notes with one press.

ROOM 5 · STEP 7 OF 7



A **rest** is a beat of **silence**. You count it just like a note, but you do not play.

The crotchet rest lasts 1 beat. The minim rest sits on a line for 2. The semibreve rest hangs under a line for 4.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C, C, then lift your hand for one beat, then C: 1, 2, (rest), 4. Keep counting through the silence.

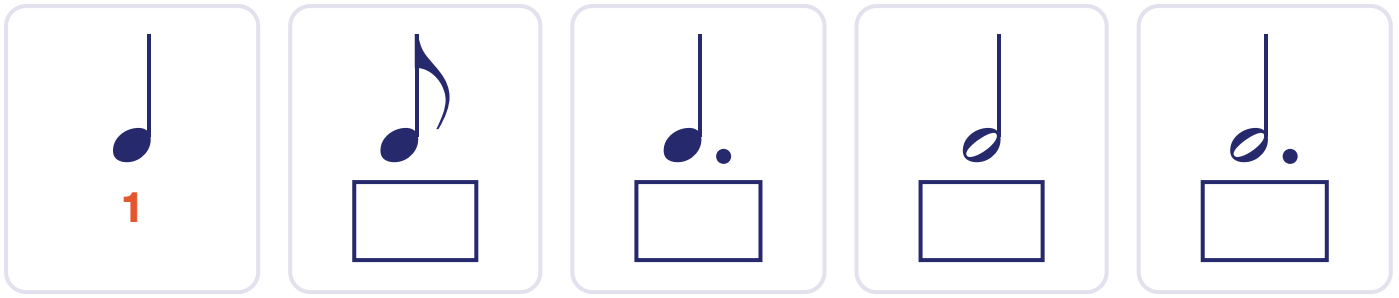
HOW LONG IS A NOTE?

ROOM 5 · PRACTISE

1 How many beats?

★☆☆

Write the beats. A quaver is ½. The first is done.



2 Add them up

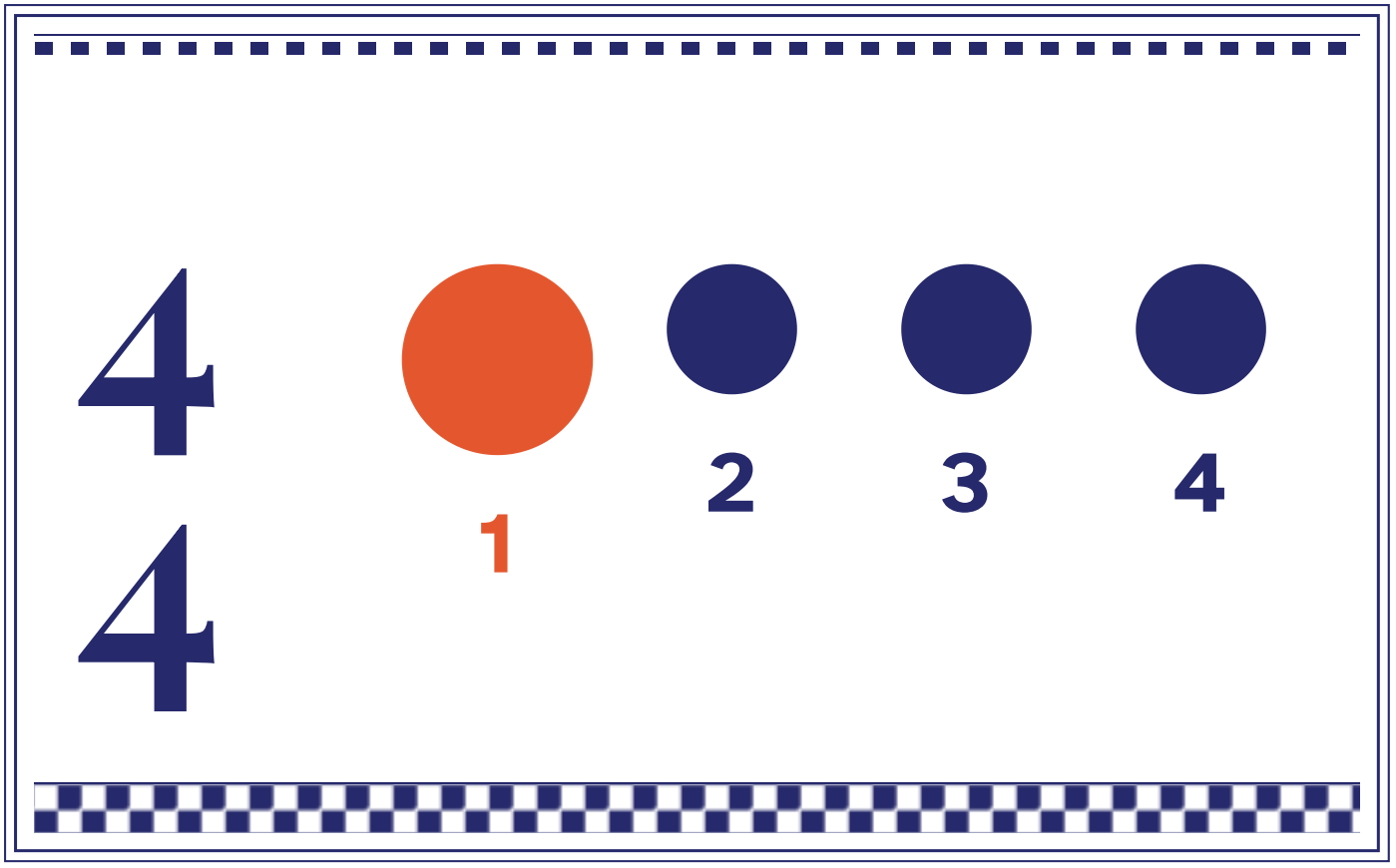
★★☆

Write the total number of beats. The first is done.

NOTES	BEATS
	1
	
	
 (tied)	
	

ROOM 6 · STEP 1 OF 3

SCAN TO LISTEN



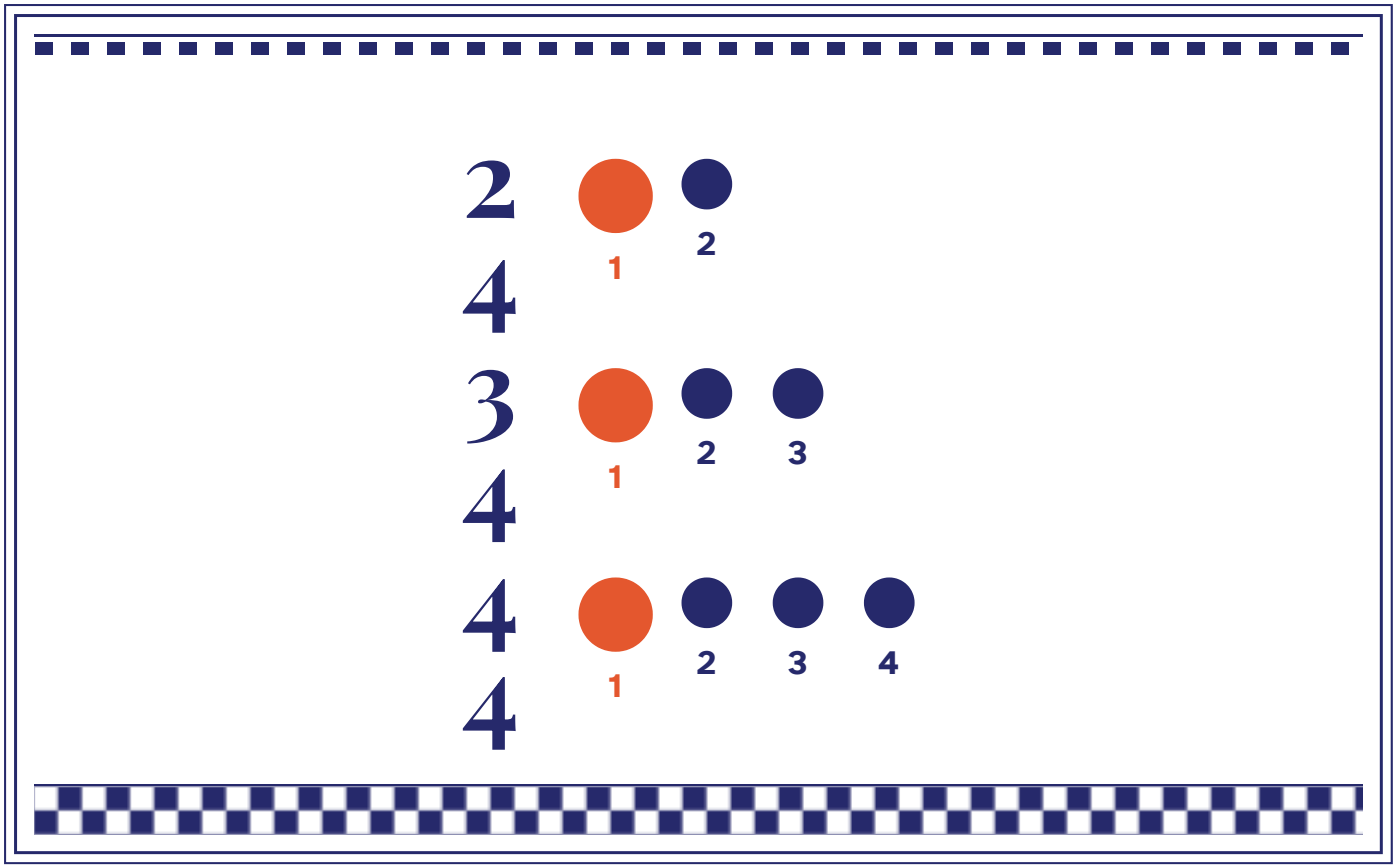
The two numbers at the start are the **time signature**.

The **top number** says how many beats are in every bar. The bottom 4 says each beat is a crotchet.

At the piano

- [ ] Clap four beats in a bar, the first one stronger: ONE two three four. ○

ROOM 6 · STEP 2 OF 3



Two in a bar marches: left, right. **Three** in a bar swings round, like a waltz. **Four** in a bar walks.

Beat 1 is always the strongest.

At the piano

- [ ] Clap each one: ONE two · ONE two three · ONE two three four. Which does your piece use? ○

ROOM 6 · STEP 3 OF 3



A word above the first bar tells you **how fast** the beat goes. The words are Italian.

Andante is a walking speed. **Moderato** is in the middle. **Allegro** is quick and lively.

At the piano

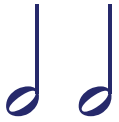
- [ ] Clap four beats Andante, then Moderato, then Allegro. Find the speed word at the top of your piece. ◯

ROOM 6 · PRACTISE

1 How many beats in a bar?

★☆☆

Write the top number that fits. The first is done.

ONE BAR	BEATS
	3
	☐
	☐
	☐
	☐

2 Two, three or four?

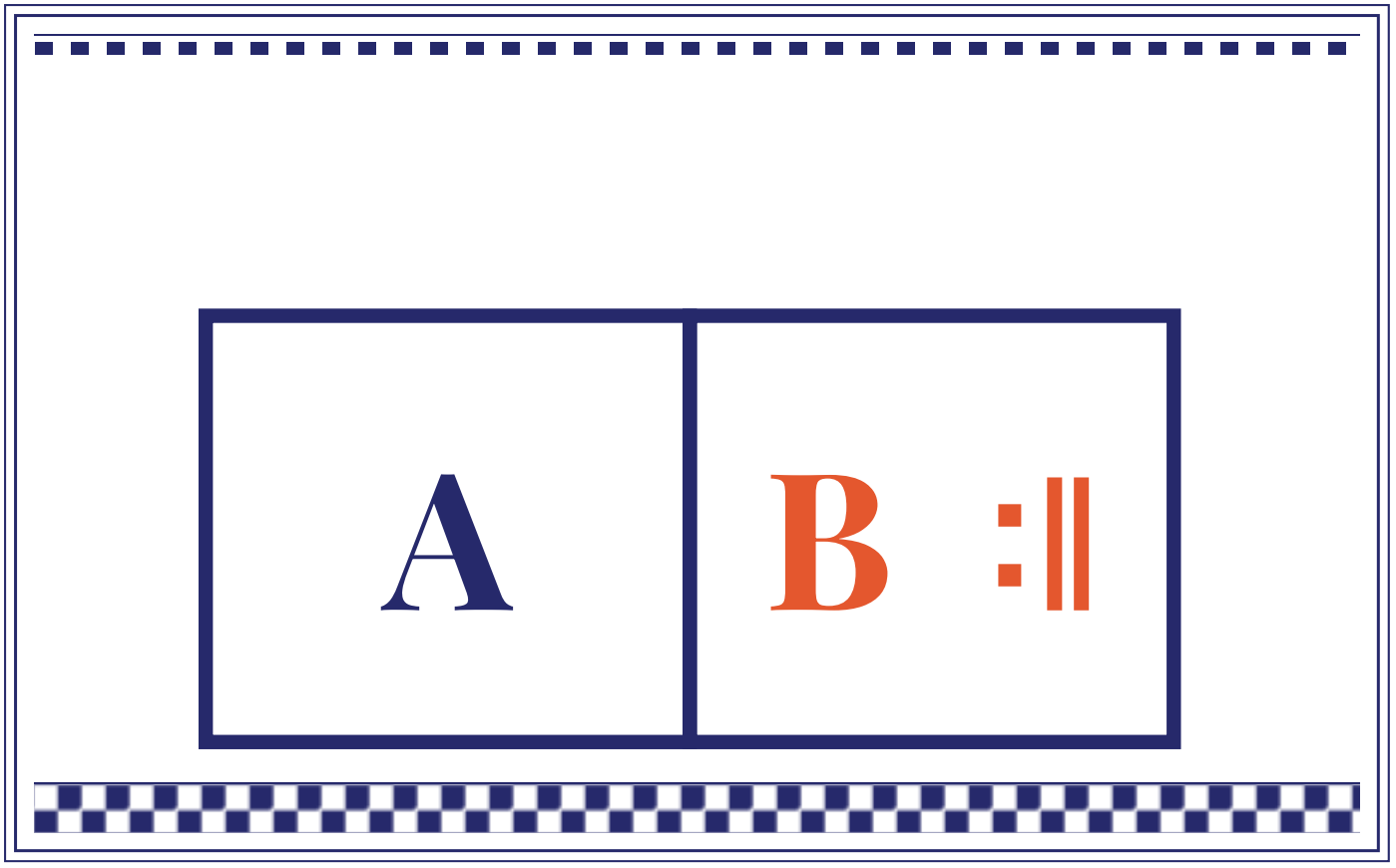
★★☆

Clap each one with a strong beat 1. Write 2, 3 or 4.

IT FEELS LIKE…	BEATS IN A BAR
LEFT right, LEFT right	☐
ONE two three, ONE two three	☐
ONE two three four	☐

ROOM 7 · STEP 1 OF 2

SCAN TO LISTEN



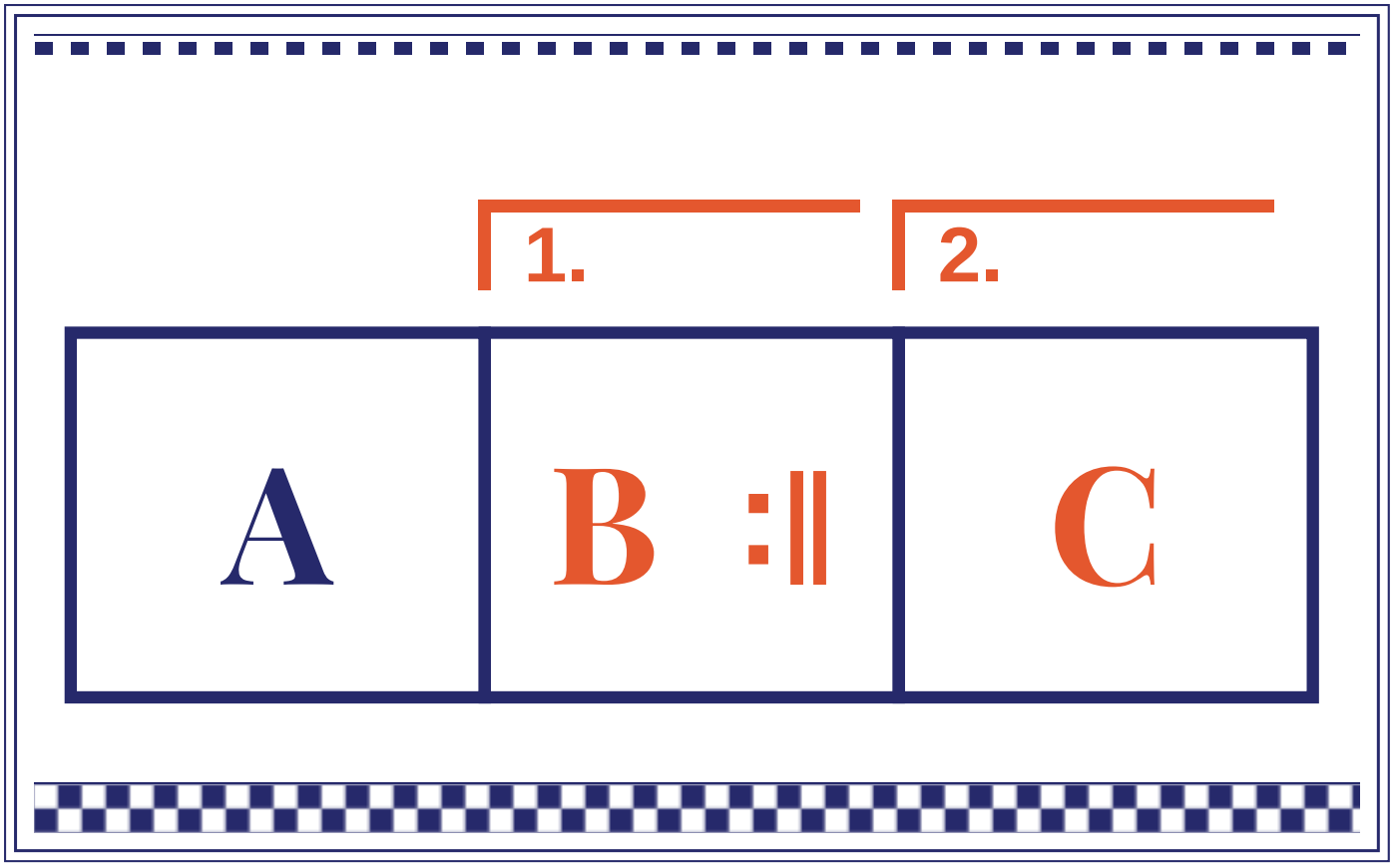
Two dots beside a double bar line make a **repeat sign**. It means: **go back and play it again**.

So this music is played A B, then A B once more.

At the piano

- [ ] Find a repeat sign in your book. Play up to it, then go back to the start and play it again. ○

ROOM 7 · STEP 2 OF 2



Sometimes the ending changes. The bar marked **1** is played the first time only.

The second time, **skip it** and jump to the bar marked **2**: A B, then A C.

At the piano

- [ ] Say the order out loud for this picture: A, B, back, A, C. Then look for a first-time bar in your music. ◯

ROOM 7 · PRACTISE

1 Write the order

★☆☆

Each letter is one bar. At a repeat sign, go back to the start once. Write the letters in the order you play them. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
A B 𝄆	**A B A B**
A 𝄆 B	
A B C 𝄆	
A B 𝄆 C	

2 First and second time

★★☆

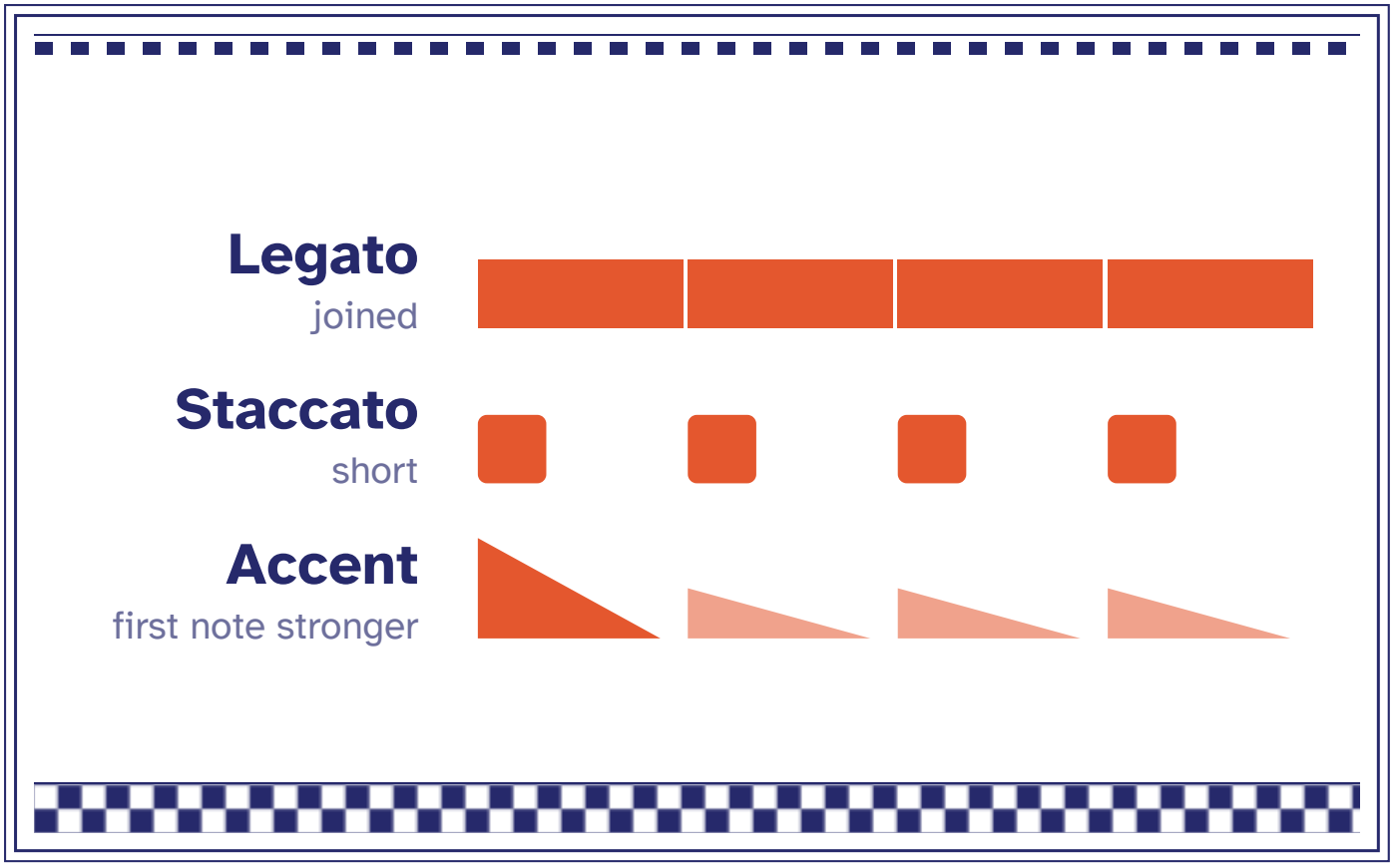
The bar marked 1 is played the first time only; the second time you skip it and play the bar marked 2. Write the order. The first is done.

THE MUSIC	YOU PLAY
A [1. B 𝄆 [2. C	**A B A C**
A B [1. C 𝄆 [2. D	
A [1. B 𝄆 [2. C D	

TOUCH: SMOOTH AND SHORT

ROOM 8 · STEP 1 OF 2

SCAN TO LISTEN



The same notes can be played in different ways. **Legato** means smooth and joined. **Staccato**, a dot above or below the note head, means short. (A dot *after* a note makes it longer.)

An **accent** (>) means that note is stronger.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C D E F G smoothly, each finger passing the sound to the next. Then play it staccato, like hot keys.

TOUCH: SMOOTH AND SHORT

ROOM 8 · STEP 2 OF 2



A curved line over **different** notes is a **slur**. Play them smoothly, in one breath, and lift gently at the end.

A tie joins the same note; a slur joins different ones.

At the piano

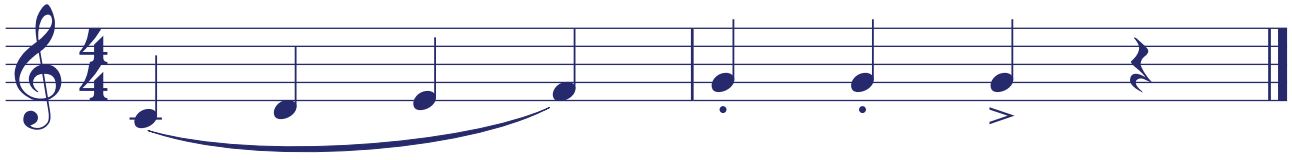
- [ ] Play C D E F as one slur: sink into the C, float off the F.

ROOM 8 · PRACTISE

1 Which notes are short?

★★☆

Look at the music and complete the sentences. The first is done.



Bar 1 is played [joined] (joined or short).

In bar 2, [ ] notes have a staccato dot.

The last G has an [ ] .

2 Slur or tie?

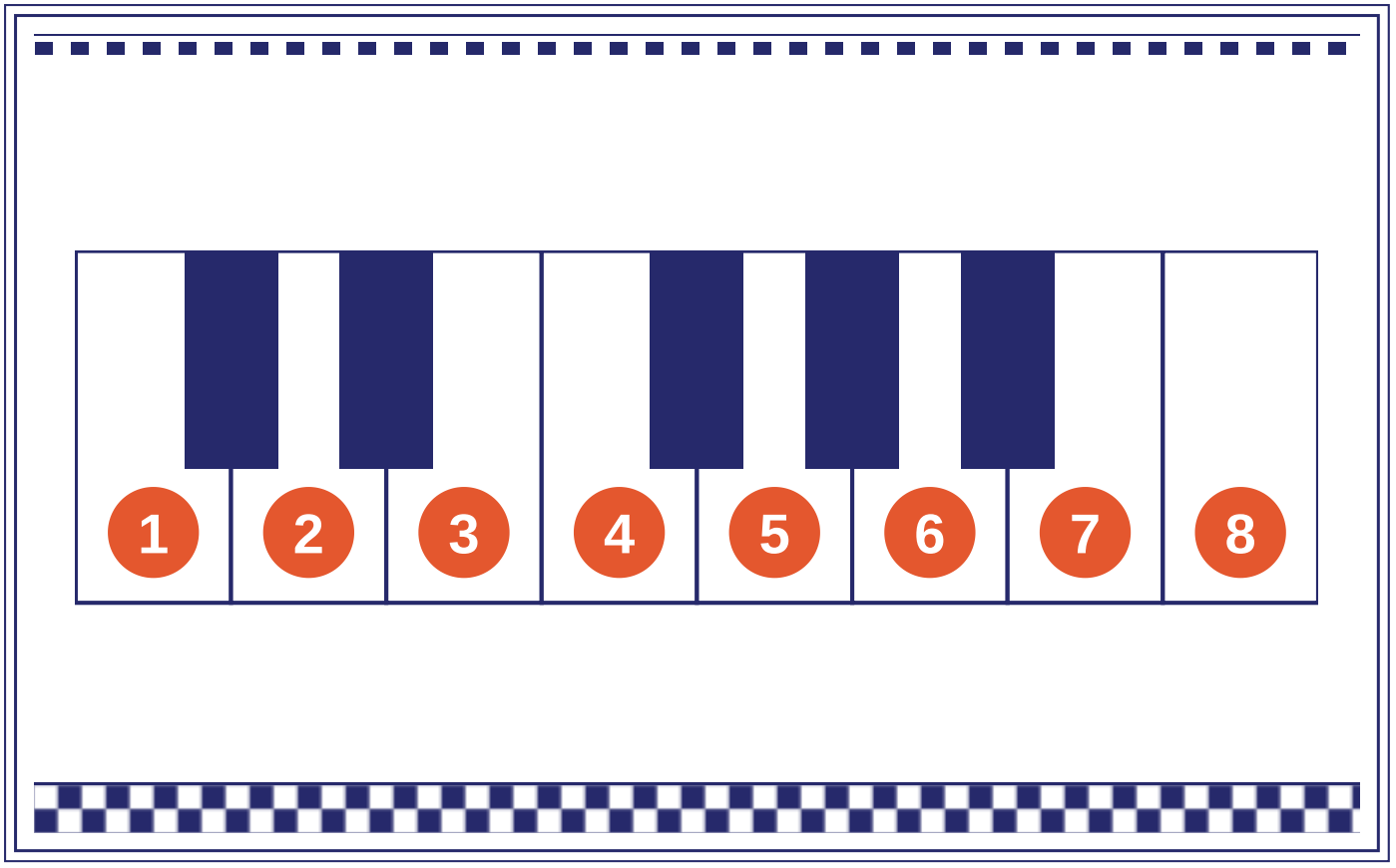
★☆☆

Circle slur or tie. The first is done.

a curve over C D E	**(slur)** · **tie**
a curve joining G and G	**slur** · **tie**
a curve over E F	**slur** · **tie**
a curve joining two Bs	**slur** · **tie**

ROOM 9 · STEP 1 OF 4

SCAN TO LISTEN



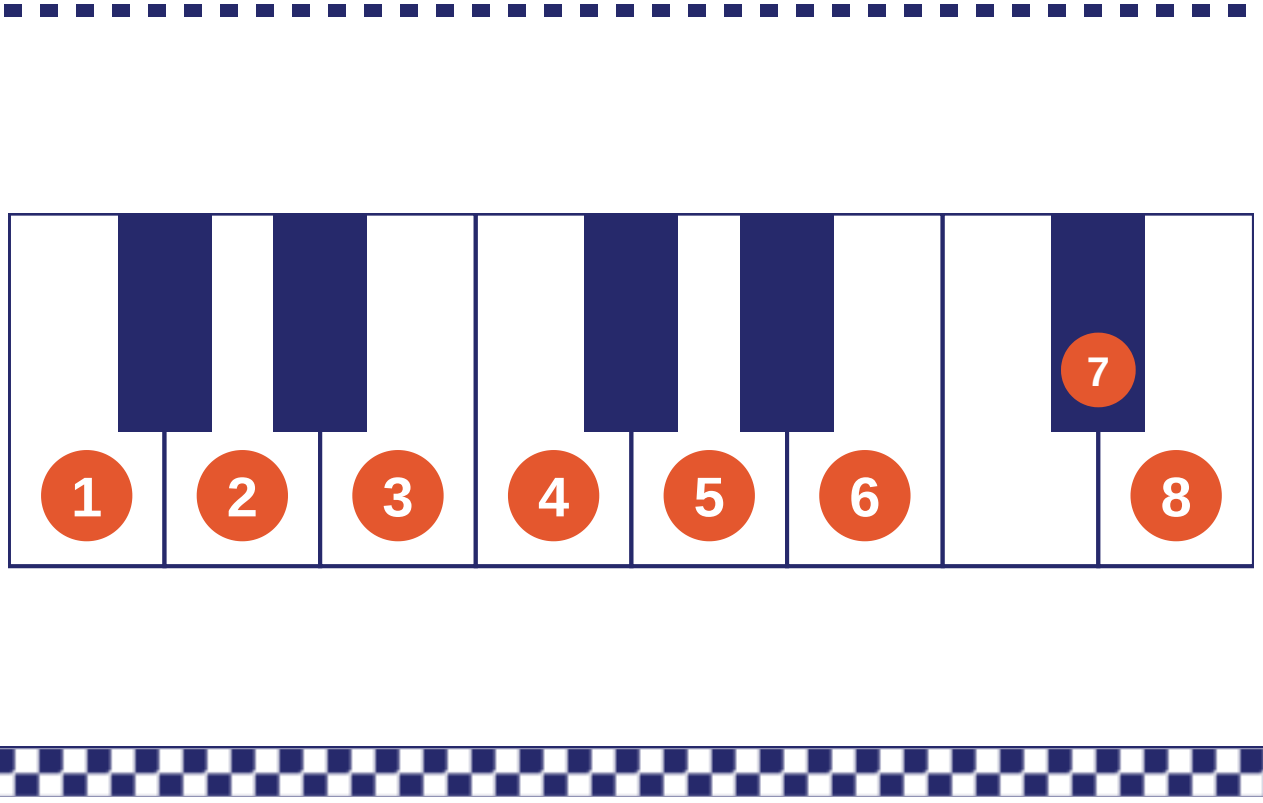
A **scale** is a ladder of eight notes. Play the white keys from C to the next C and you have **C major**.

Notes **3–4** and **7–8** are close together, with no black key between. Every other pair has a black key between.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C major going up with one finger, saying the numbers 1 to 8. Listen for the two close steps. (Fingering comes in step 3.) ◯

ROOM 9 · STEP 2 OF 4



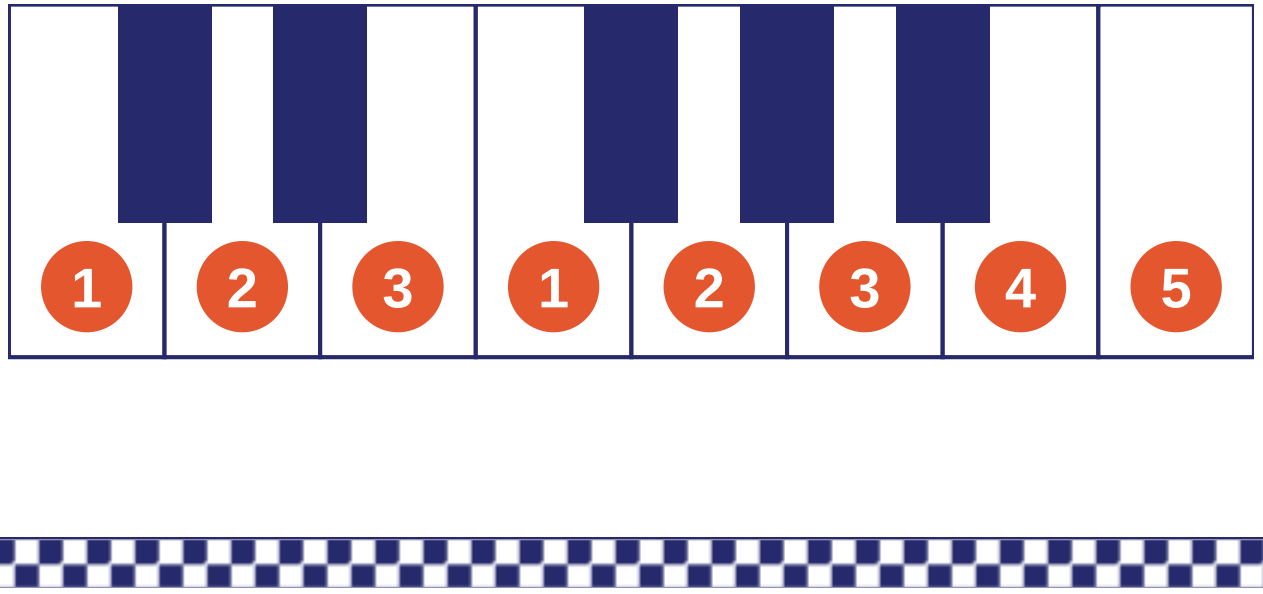
Start the same ladder on G and one note has to change: the 7th note becomes **F sharp**, so that 7–8 stay close. A **sharp** (♯) is the very next key to the right, here a black one.

That is **G major**: one sharp, F♯.

At the piano

- [ ] Play G A B C D E, then the black key F♯, then G. Now try it with a white F: hear how it sounds wrong. ◯

ROOM 9 · STEP 3 OF 4



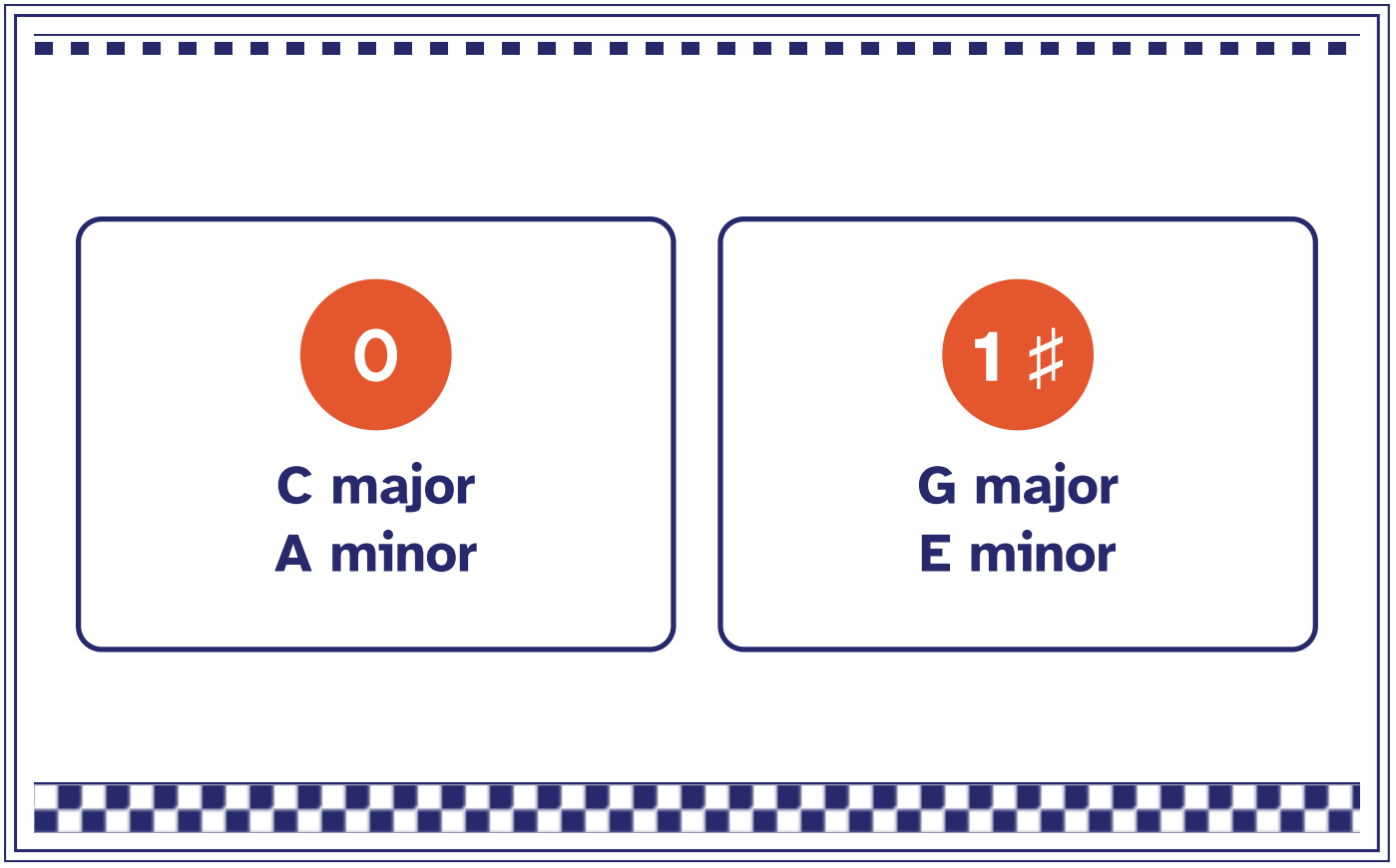
Eight notes, five fingers. Going up, the right hand plays **1 2 3**, then the **thumb tucks under** and plays **1 2 3 4 5**.

From one C to the next is one **octave**. Coming down, play 5 4 3 2 1, then finger 3 crosses over: 3 2 1.

At the piano

- [ ] Right hand, C major, one octave up and down, slowly. Say the finger numbers. Your teacher will show you the left hand. ◯

ROOM 9 · STEP 4 OF 4



Music in G major would need a sharp on every F. So one sharp is printed once, right after the clef. That is the **key signature**.

No sharps: C major or A minor. One sharp: G major or E minor.

At the piano

- [ ] Look at the start of your piece. How many sharps are after the clef? Say which two keys it could be. ○

ROOM 9 · PRACTISE

1 Write the scale

★☆☆

Write the eight notes going up. The first is done.

SCALE	NOTES
C major	C D E F G A B C
G major	

2 Where are the close steps?

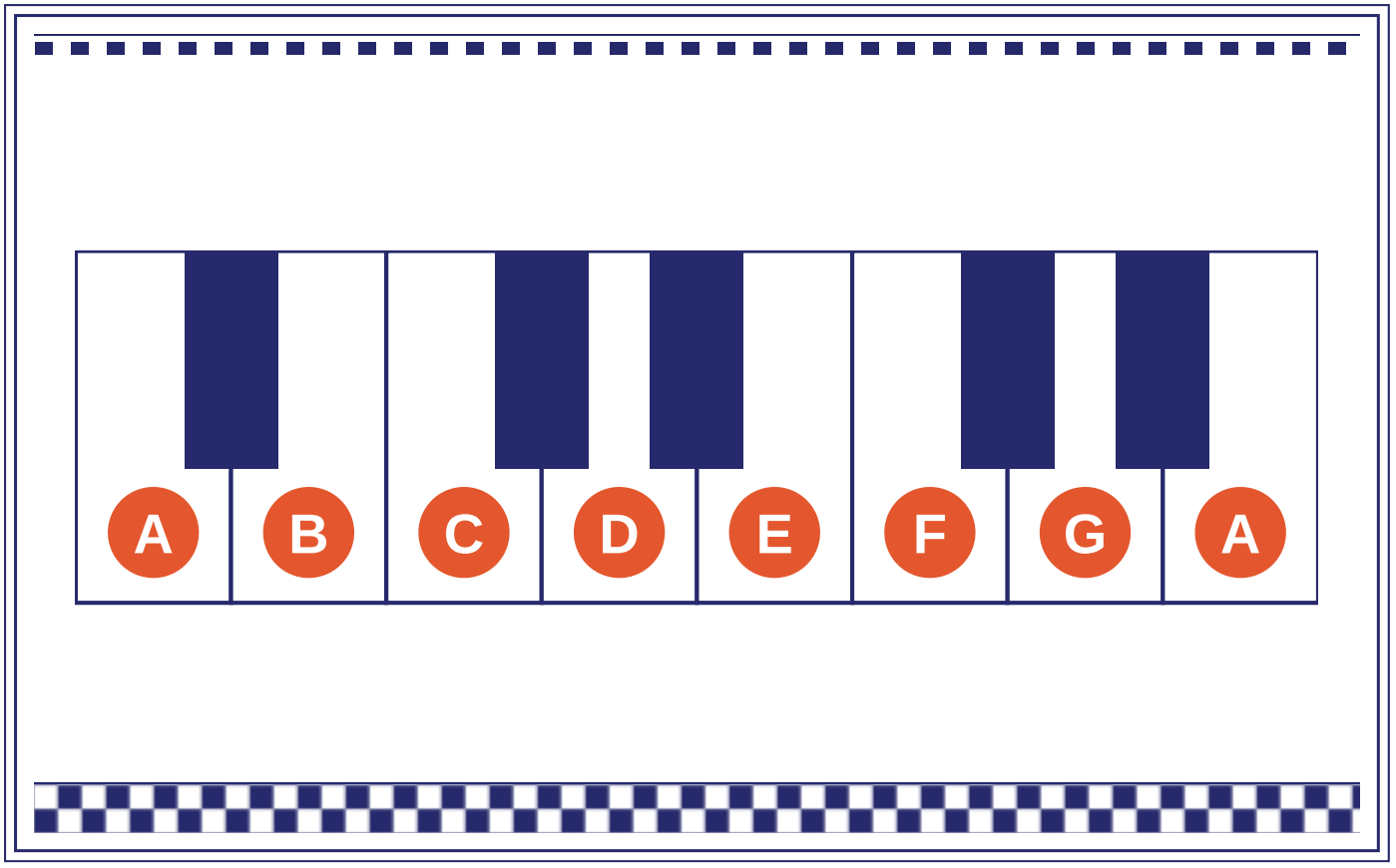
★★☆

In a major scale two pairs of notes are close together, with no key between. Write their numbers.

Notes ☐ – ☐ and notes ☐ – ☐

ROOM 10 · STEP 1 OF 3

SCAN TO LISTEN



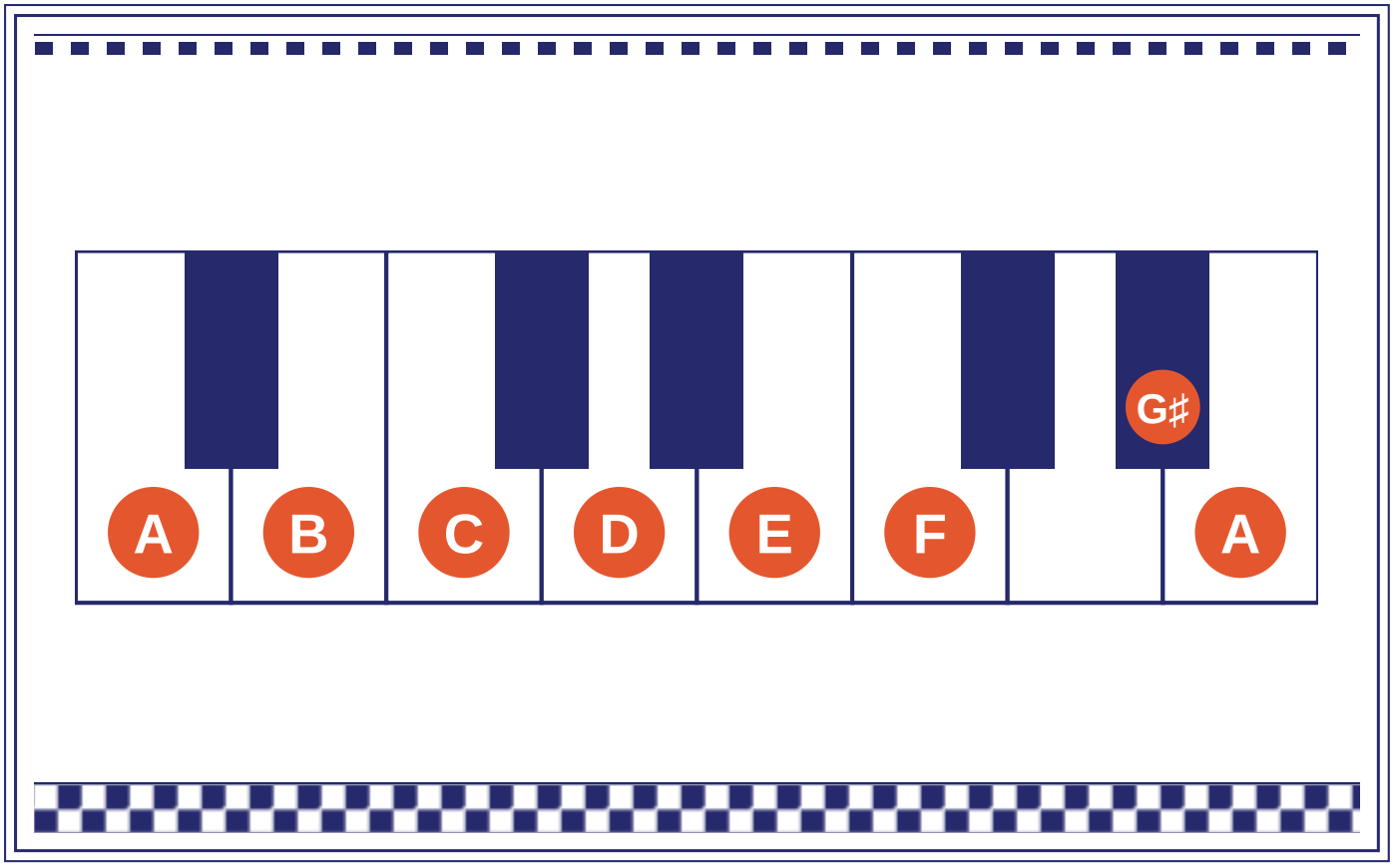
Play the white keys from A to A and you have **A minor**. It uses the same notes as C major, but A is home, and it sounds darker.

This plain form is the **natural minor**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play C major up and down, then A natural minor. Same white notes, a different mood.

ROOM 10 · STEP 2 OF 3



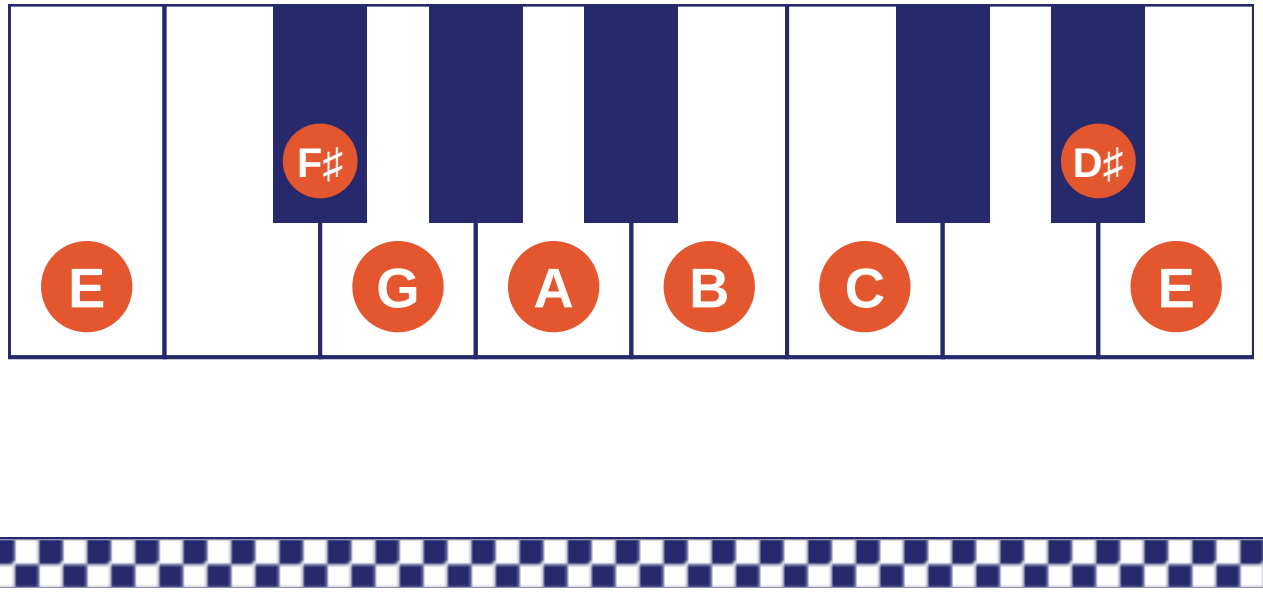
Raise the 7th note one key, G to **G sharp**, and the scale pulls strongly back home.

This is the **harmonic minor**: A B C D E F G♯ A.

At the piano

- [ ] Play A harmonic minor slowly. Stop on G♯ and feel how much it wants to go up to A. ○

ROOM 10 · STEP 3 OF 3



E minor uses the same notes as G major, so it keeps **F sharp**. E is home.

For the harmonic minor, raise its 7th note too: D becomes **D sharp**.

At the piano

- [ ] Play E natural minor (with F♯), then E harmonic minor (F♯ and D♯). ◯

ROOM 10 · PRACTISE

1 Write the scale

★☆☆

Write the eight notes going up. The first is done.

SCALE	NOTES
A natural minor	**A B C D E F G A**
A harmonic minor	
E natural minor	
E harmonic minor	

2 Which note is raised?

★★☆

In the harmonic minor the 7th note goes up one key. Write it. The first is done.

SCALE	THE 7TH NOTE BECOMES
A harmonic minor	**G sharp**
E harmonic minor	

3 Same notes as...

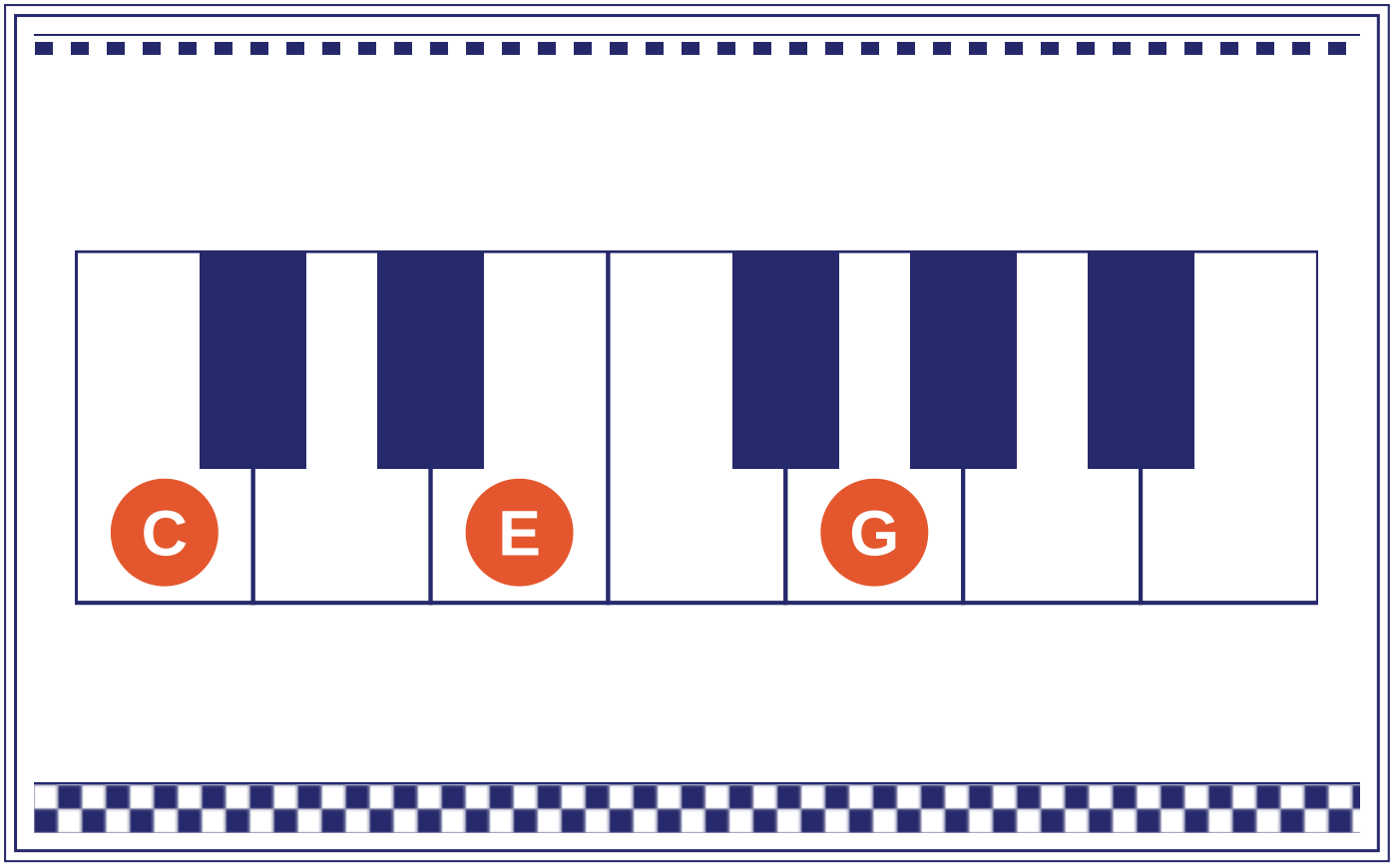
★☆☆

Each minor scale shares its notes with a major scale. Write it.

MINOR	MAJOR
A minor	**C major**
E minor	

ROOM 11 · STEP 1 OF 2

SCAN TO LISTEN



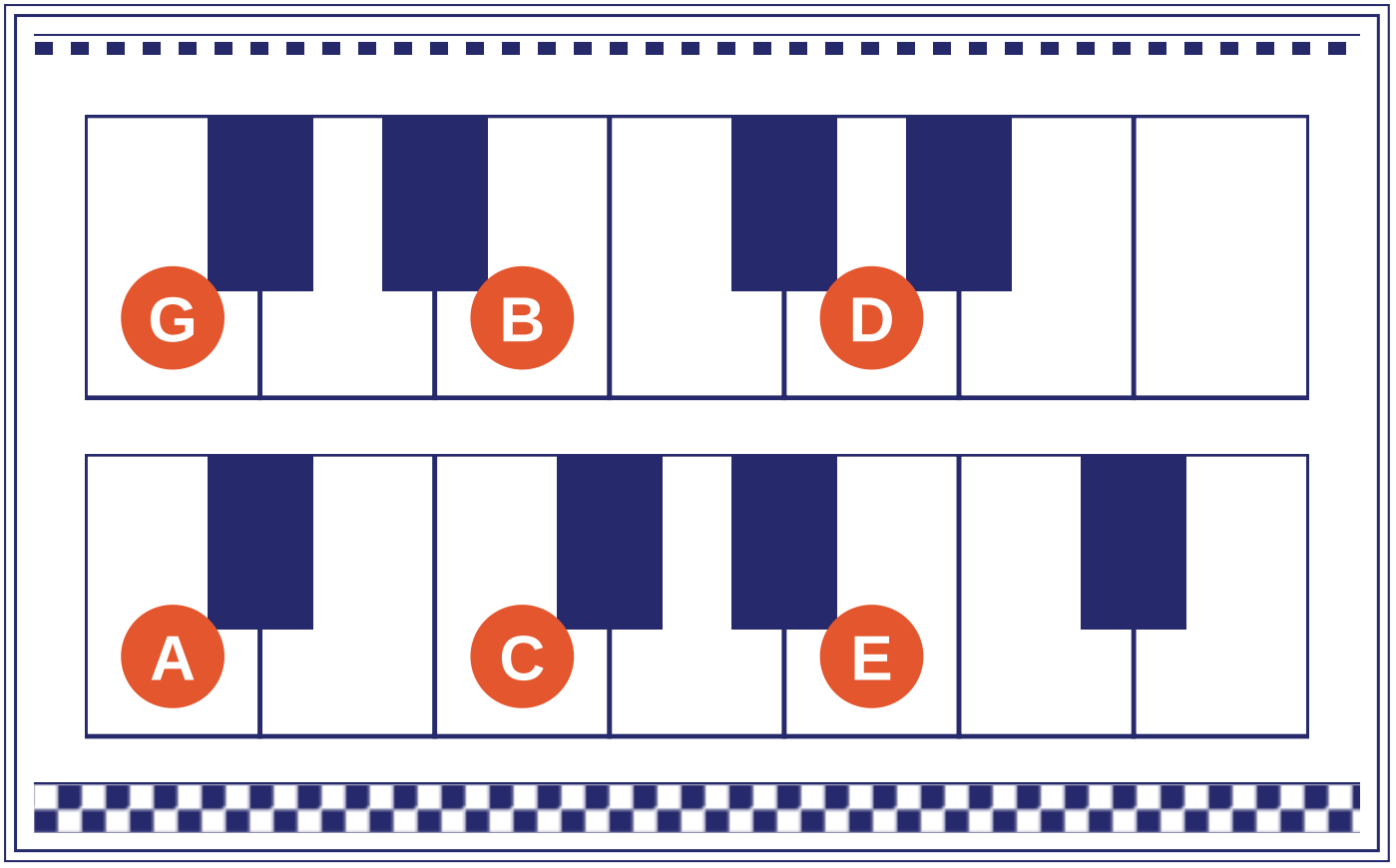
A **chord** is three or more notes played together. The simplest chord is a **triad**: three notes.

To build one: **play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one**. C, E, G.

At the piano

- [ ] Right hand fingers 1, 3 and 5 on C, E and G. Play them one at a time, then all together.

ROOM 11 · STEP 2 OF 2



The same shape works on other white keys too. On G it gives **G B D**. On A it gives **A C E**.

The bottom note names the triad. C and G sound bright: **major**. A sounds darker: **minor**.

At the piano

- [ ] Keep your hand in the triad shape and move it: C E G, then G B D, then A C E. ◯

ROOM 11 · PRACTISE

1 Build the triad

★☆☆

Play one, skip one, play one, skip one, play one. Write the three notes. The first is done.

ON	THE TRIAD
C	**C E G**
G	
A	
E	

2 Major or minor?

★★☆

Play each triad and listen: bright or dark? Circle one. The first is done.

TRIAD	
C E G	(major) · minor
A C E	major · minor
G B D	major · minor
E G B	major · minor

ROOM 12 · STEP 1 OF 1

SCAN TO PLAY

1 **Clap the beat**

2 **Echo the rhythm**

3 **Sing the tune**

4 **Higher or lower?**

Listen first, then play. Good ears make good fingers.

Four listening games belong to this level. Each one is in the app: scan the code and play one each day.

At the piano

- [ ] Before you play a note, sing it. Then play it and listen: were you right?

ROOM 12 · PRACTISE

1 Clap the beat ★☆☆

A grown-up plays in two or in three, slow or quick. Clap the beat, and keep clapping when the music stops.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

2 Echo the rhythm ★☆☆

They clap a short pattern. Clap it back exactly.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

3 Sing the notes ★☆☆

They play five notes slowly, one at a time. Sing each one after it.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○

4 Higher or lower? ★☆☆

They play two notes. Say whether the second is higher or lower. Tick a circle for each day you play these games.

○ ○ ○ ○ ○